HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE*

Tuesday, April 7, 2026

mint

livemint.com

Government eyes loan subsidy for induction stoves ▶P1

Oppo to Samsung raise prices by up to 40% on chip deficit ▶P1

Dear Daughter,

Others see you throwing a teenage tantrum.
I see you standing your ground.

They see you as stubborn, not listening to their advice.

I see you setting boundaries for yourself.
Some see you changing your mind all the time.

I see a girl listening to her heart all the time.

They see you being friendly with boys.
I see you breaking their rules and judgements.

Some see you rebelling.
I see a girl expressing herself.

I see you, my daughter
16 and already owning your story
And I couldn't be more proud.

Love, from Dad.


Love so natural
only a natural
diamond will do.
love,
from dad
COLLECTION
FOR SECOND PIERCING
FIND A JEWELLER
DE BEERS GROUP
A DIAMOND IS FOREVER

HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 9 NO. 83

Tuesday, April 7, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

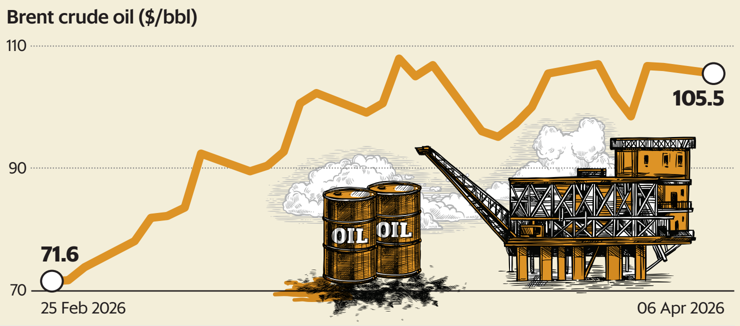
Why output hike by Opec+ won't cool oil prices

BY RITURAJ BARUAH

Oil prices have been surging since the Iran war broke out on 28 February. In a bid to ease supply concerns and prices, currently over $100 a barrel, the Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries (Opec) and its allies including Russia, together known as Opec+ will hike output in May. *Mint* explores how it might impact global prices.

Crude woes

Opec+ has agreed to increase production in May to ease oil prices, which have surged to over $100 per barrel since the Iran war began.



Source: Bloomberg

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

1 What is the global crude oil supply situation as of now, considering the strait's blockade?

With the Strait of Hormuz blocked, about 20% of energy supply from the Gulf nations has been nearly cut off for over a month. Supplies from Russia and Iran are flowing due to temporary waivers on the US sanctions. Global demand from these two sources, as well as alternative markets in Africa and South America, have surged. In a 12 March report, the International Energy Agency (IEA) said that with supplies down from about 20 million barrels before the war to a trickle now and storage filling up, the Gulf countries have cut their oil output by at least 10 million barrels per day (bpd). It said global oil supply is seen plunging by 8 million bpd in March.

TURN TO PAGE 06

QUICK EDIT

No escape from war

Effects of the global disruptions resulting from America and Israel's war on Iran have started to show on India's economy. On Monday, the final HSBC India services purchasing managers' index (PMI), compiled by S&P Global, showed a fall to 57.5 in March from 58.1 in February, marking the slowest rate of expansion in 14 months. This follows a bigger fall in the manufacturing PMI to 53.9 in March from 56.9, the lowest level in nearly four years. Relatively speaking, the services sector has done better. Not only has it outperformed the factory sector, it remains above its long-span average of 54.4. Encouragingly, foreign orders climbed to their second highest on record while job creation picked up by the PMI was the strongest since mid-2025. Yet, an overall loss in economic momentum now seems clear. A war-driven rise in input costs might already be weighing on demand. India's high dependence on oil imports is just one point of exposure to this external shock. The longer the war lasts, the steeper will be the inflation, growth and other challenges we face. Unfortunately, there is no sign of an end to hostilities. Business activity in India may yet find it harder to escape the consequences.

mint

PLAIN FACTS

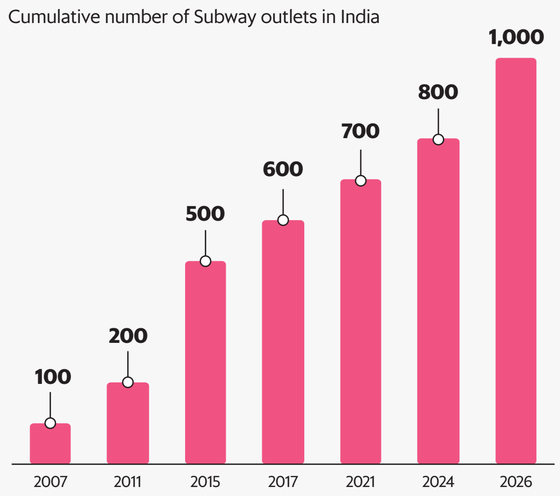
FAST-FOOD CHAINS BET ON INDIA BOOM

BY DEEPA VASUDEVAN

As Subway contracts in the US, it is growing in India—a signal of a broader shift, as rising incomes, rapid urbanization, and delivery-led demand fuel a quick service restaurant (QSR) boom, setting the stage for faster growth.

The number of Subway outlets in India has expanded at a steady pace

Cumulative number of Subway outlets in India



Source: Subway South Asia LinkedIn, media reports

The organized QSR market is dominated by global restaurant chains

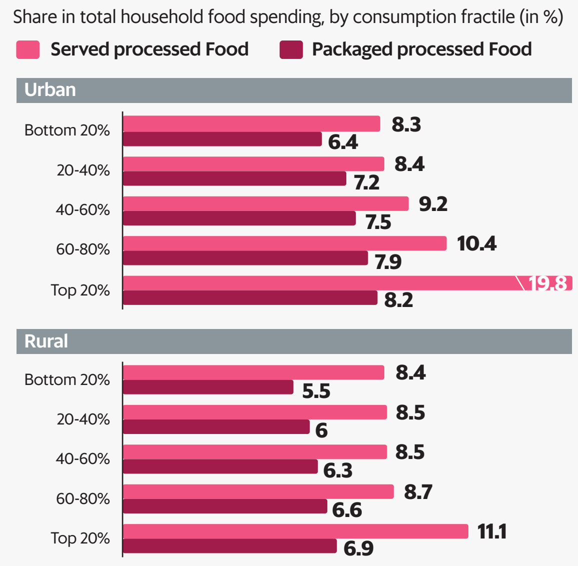
Details of QSR market in India, 2024-25

QSR	Brands	Revenue (₹ crore)
Jubilant FoodWorks	Domino's, Popeyes, Dunkin', Hong's Kitchen, Coffy	8,141
Devayani International	KFC, Pizza Hut, Costa, Vaango, Sanook Kitchen, New York Fries	3,399
Westlife Foodworld	McDonald's	2,492
Sapphire Foods India	KFC, Pizza Hut, Taco Bell	2,451
Restaurants Brands International	Tim Hortons, Burger King, Popeyes, Firehouse Subs	1,967

QSR: Quick service restaurant. *Source: Company annual reports*

Affluent households tend to spend relatively more on outside food

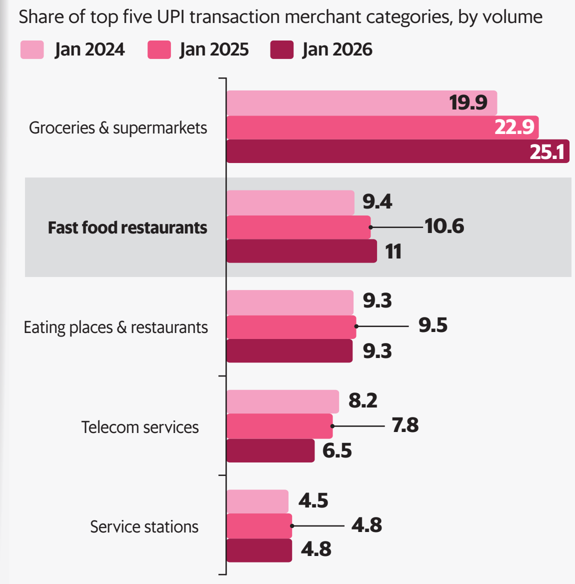
Share in total household food spending, by consumption fractile (in %)



Source: Changes in India's Food Consumption and Policy Implications by Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister

QSR spending is among the top UPI transaction categories by volume

Share of top five UPI transaction merchant categories, by volume



QSR: Quick service restaurant. *Source: National Payments Corp. of India*

The promoters of HT Media Ltd, which publishes Mint, and Jubilant FoodWorks are closely related. There are, however, no promoter cross-holdings.

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

Subway—the ubiquitous sandwich shop—ranks among the largest US restaurant brands by store count. Yet its footprint in the world's largest economy is shrinking. More than 600 outlets shut in 2024, and by December 2025 the US network fell below 20,000 for the first time in two decades.

This decline reflects intensifying competition, shifting consumer preferences, over-aggressive expansion in earlier years, and changing location dynamics.

The picture in India could not be more different.

Subway opened its first outlet in a New Delhi mall in 2001. It reached 100 stores by 2010, 600 by 2017, and crossed 1,000 in 2026. Growth has been steady, in sharp contrast to the decline in the US market.

COMPLEX MARKET

Like other fast-food chains, Subway sits within India's QSR industry, which is riding the country's growth tailwinds.

The industry is complex and varied, spanning small, independent, neighbourhood Udipi-style eateries to homegrown chains such as Haldiram's and Saravanaa Bhavan, and global franchises like Subway and McDonald's. Yet the organized segment is dominated by a handful of firms controlling global brands, with estimated revenues of about ₹20,000 crore in 2024-25.

The top five companies are listed, and reports suggest that Subway may be eyeing an initial public offering. The segment has seen a surge in fundraising, mergers and acquisitions, and consolidation; all of which signal strong growth prospects.

A Mordor Intelligence report estimates India's QSR industry will grow at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of over 9% during 2026-31, to reach $47.3 billion in 2031. The outlook is underpinned by rising incomes, changing demographics, and the rise of food aggregators and delivery platforms.

LIFESTYLE CHANGE

Rising incomes allow households to indulge in greater discretionary spending, including eating out. As incomes rise, there is a tendency to seek out a variety of cuisines and food choices, and a large part of that experience is derived from out-of-home food (dining in as well as delivery).

Macro-level data supports this theory: between 2013-14 and 2023-24, aggregate private final consumption expenditure (PFCE) on restaurants and hotels grew at an 8.1% CAGR, almost double the 4.4% growth in food expenditure, and in line with the 11% growth in per capita GDP.

Granular data also shows a shift away from home-cooked food, especially in the more affluent segments. For example, data from the 2022-23 household consumption expenditure survey showed that spending on served processed food was 19.8% of the total food expenditure for the top consuming class of urban households, and 11.1% for rural households.

Shifting demographics favour the QSR industry.

India's urban population has expanded rapidly in absolute numbers: estimates of the number of urban residents range from half a million to a billion plus, depending on how urban is defined.

Urbanization typically results in a breakdown of the traditional joint family structure, which is replaced by nuclear families or even single-person households. Shrinking urban households often have more than one earning member; busy lifestyles and long commutes result in a willingness to pay for services that are time-saving and convenient.

Here's where QSRs come in: a multi-income family can afford to order in or eat out more often than earlier generations. In fact, UPI transaction data reveals that fast food restaurants and other eating places are among the top merchant categories, and now account for a quarter of the total volume of spending.

CULTURAL SHIFT

India's demographic profile is also fuelling an eating-out culture. With 381 million Gen Z consumers (14-29) and 339 million millennials (30-45), the country offers a vast QSR customer base.

A wide mix of cuisines, coupled with strong localization, caters to diverse preferences. For example, McDonald's opened its first outlet in India in 1996, when the youngest millennials were born. Today, these millennials—entering their thirties—are more likely to seek out healthier options (Subway, Millet Express), while older millennials are likely to bring their families to outlets popular with kids (McDonald's, KFC, Domino's) or family-oriented Indian cuisine joints (Haldiram's).

The result: a QSR option for nearly every age, need and palate.

SHIFTING MARGINS

The growth of food aggregators and delivery platforms has reshaped the QSR industry—for better and worse.

Delivery now accounts for 40-70% of QSR sales, depending on the brand and type of food ordered. The good news is that delivery platforms have boosted reach, especially of smaller outlets.

With some premium names also offering delivery, the market has become competitive to the point where customers are spoilt for choice. At the same time, aggregator commissions have squeezed restaurant operating margins.

As the consumption journey—from purchase to payment—becomes more digital, QSRs will have to rework their business models to stay profitable. India has the customer base and spending power, but restaurants will need to offer innovative and valuable user experience to attract customers.

The author is an independent writer in economics and finance.

AT A GLANCE

- Subway's US presence is shrinking due to intense competition and over-expansion, while its Indian business is booming, recently surpassing the 1,000-store milestone.
- Rising disposable incomes and shifting urban lifestyles drive India's QSR growth, as families increasingly prioritize convenience and diverse, out-of-home dining experiences.
- A massive demographic of millennials and Gen Z consumers fuels the industry, benefiting from localized menus that cater to specific Indian dietary preferences.
- Digital delivery platforms expanded market access vastly, though high aggregator commissions will require restaurants to innovate their business models to maintain profitability.

HT | MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* | VOL. 9 NO. 83 | Rs. 15.00 | 18 PAGES

Tuesday, April 7, 2026

mint

livemint.com

Why IPOs no longer feel like easy wins ▶P10

LPG crisis fuels labour crunch, hiring cost rises 15% ▶P7

SENSEX 74,106.88 ↑ 787.33 | NIFTY 22,968.25 ↑ 255.15 | DOLLAR ₹92.90 ↓ ₹0.28 | EURO ₹107.49 ↓ ₹0.18 | OIL $105.35 ↓ $1.23 | POUND ₹123.28 ↓ ₹0.09

Govt eyes induction stove loan subsidy

State-run body taps ADB, World Bank for interest subvention

Rituraj Baruah & Manas Pimpalkhare

NEW DELHI

India is planning a major push to increase the share of electric cooking stoves in its kitchens, as a shortage of cooking gas triggered by the West Asia war continues to hit households. The plan may involve bringing in multilateral financial institutions to arrange zero-interest loans through state-run Energy Efficiency Services Ltd (EESL).

The EESL is likely to redesign and ramp up the three-year-old National Efficient Cooking Programme (NECP) to meet a surge in demand for what was largely a niche product before the conflict, two people aware of the matter said. Under the model under consideration, a third party would subsidize the interest on equated monthly instalments (EMIs), lowering the cost burden for economically weaker consumers. The existing NECP has no provision for an interest subsidy.

"EESL is in talks with several financial institutions including World Bank and ADB," one of the two people cited above said, requesting anonymity. "It would be a sort of subsidy on the interest, which the financial institutions can support with." Once the loan from the multilateral institution is tied up, EESL will use it to support zero interest loans for induction stoves.

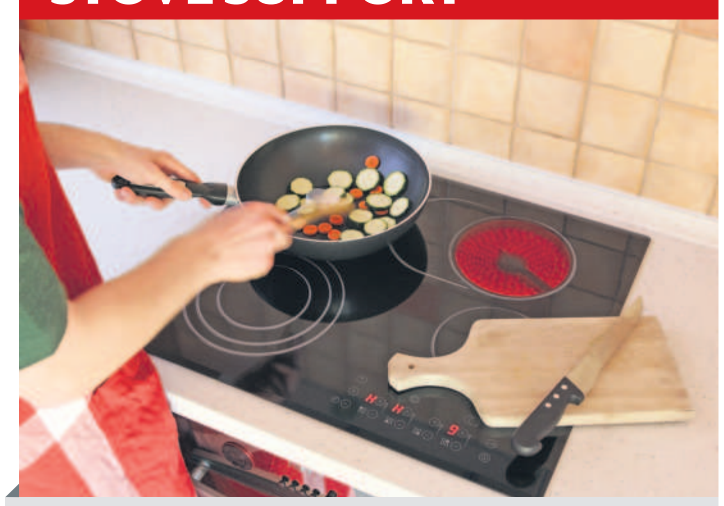
"Under this model, a tie-up with financing private or public sector banks may be worked out wherein if a person procures a cookstove from EESL on EMI, then the consumer needs to pay only the principal part of it every month, and the interest will be paid by the financial institution such as World Bank or ADB, which may partner with EESL, every month," the person added.

Demand for electric cookstoves shot up after the West Asia war

TURN TO PAGE 9

ISTOCKPHOTO

STOVE SUPPORT



HOT MEAL

- **NECP,** launched in 2023, may be redesigned, ramped up
- **EESL** eyes interest subvention for the economically weak
- **TALKS** on with World Bank, ADB, for zero-interest loans

Price phase

India saw smartphone sales of over $43 billion through 2025.

	Number of devices whose prices have been hiked	Range of price hike (%)	Market share (%)
Vivo	11	4-40	19.3
Samsung	2	27-36	14.1
Oppo	15	4-41	13.3
Realme	9	6-53	9.9
Xiaomi	7	3-32	9

Market share as of December 2025.

Source: IDC India, All India Mobile Retailers Association (Aimra)

mint

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

Samsung to Xiaomi raise smartphone prices by up to 40%

Shouvik Das

shouvik.das@livemint.com

NEW DELHI

The West Asia war and a memory chip scarcity have finally spilled over into smartphone prices, with leading smartphone makers raising prices by as much as 40%.

India's top three smartphone brands Vivo, Oppo and Samsung, and their smaller rivals Realme, Xiaomi have raised prices across their portfolios, company emails to retailers show. The hikes are significant: smartphones make for India's single-largest electronics category, with sales of over $43 billion through 2025. However, the segment has struggled since the covid pandemic in 2021, as the market got increasingly saturated.

While companies so far managed single-digit revenue growth on the back of rising premium phone sales, the current market conditions come as a double whammy: consumers are deferring phone purchases due to rising prices of basic needs such as cooking gas even as the rise in prices does nothing to aid the ailing market.

Emails on the price increases show that the hikes are sweeping, said retailers across India who received them over the past one month, requesting anonymity since they were not authorized to share the infor-

TURN TO PAGE 6

Crash, plane crunch drive traffic pain for airlines

Dipali Banka

dipali.banka@livemint.com

MUMBAI

India's domestic air passenger traffic growth was already cooling from the highs of post-pandemic revenge travel. Last fiscal is estimated to have been the worst since then because of multiple setbacks–grounded planes, frequent disruptions and heightened regulatory scrutiny after the country's worst air crash in decades.

Air passenger traffic rose 1.6% between April and February, according to Icra Ltd's note published last month. The ratings agency estimates an up to 3% growth in fiscal year 2026 (FY26).

The number of Indians flying grew by 59% and 56% in FY22 and FY23, respectively, according to data from the civil aviation regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA).

This growth slowed to 16% in FY24 and 7.6% in the following year.

The slowdown, however, does not represent a lack of demand. Passenger load factor, a measure of occupancy levels in a flight, remained

TURN TO PAGE 9

DON'T MISS

REUTERS

Air India CEO Campbell Wilson quits, currently on notice

Air India CEO Campbell Wilson has stepped down from the helm of India's second-largest airline and is serving his notice period, two people aware of the matter said. *Mint* could not independently ascertain when his notice ends or if a successor has been found. >P9

Sebi eyes initiative to bolster board independence

Sebi is working on a collaborative framework with corporates, academia and professional bodies to expand pipeline and effectiveness of independent directors, even as recent boardroom tensions at HDFC Bank sharpen scrutiny on governance standards. >P4

Serum Institute, Trivitron in talks to take MyLab global

Adar Poonawalla-led Serum Institute of India is in talks to partner with medical device maker Trivitron Healthcare to scale up its investment in MyLab Discovery Solutions and expand the Pune-based diagnostics provider's operations internationally. >P3

Vedanta fails to stall Adani's JAL resolution plan at SC

The Supreme Court (SC) on Monday refused to stay the implementation of Adani Enterprises Ltd's ₹14,543 crore resolution plan for bankrupt Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL), rejecting a challenge by mining major Vedanta Ltd. >P5

MINT SHORTS

Moody's retains Baa3 rating for India but warns of risks from war

New Delhi: International rating agency Moody's retained its Baa3 (BBB-) sovereign credit rating for India with a stable outlook, but warned that the ongoing conflict in West Asia would moderate real GDP growth to 6% in FY27 and raise inflation risks. The stable outlook incorporates India's gradually improving fiscal metrics since emerging from the pandemic and resilient growth prospects compared with peers, the rating agency said. **SUBHASH NARAYAN**

Summer crop sowing inches up; rice cultivation area declines

PTI

New Delhi: India's summer crop sowing has edged up marginally so far this season, with higher acreage under pulses, coarse cereals and oilseeds offsetting a sharp decline in rice, amid concerns over input supplies following the war in West Asia. Total area under summer crops stood at 5.82 million hectares as of 3 April, up from 5.78 million hectares a year earlier, as per the ministry of agriculture. **VIJAY C ROY**

Cost of home-cooked veg thali flat in March, non-veg falls 1%: Crisil

New Delhi: The cost of a home-cooked vegetarian thali remained unchanged year-on-year in March, while the price of a non-vegetarian thali declined by about 1%, mainly because of lower broiler prices, according to the latest Crisil Roti Rice Rate report. The report calculates the average cost of preparing a thali, or a meal, based on prevailing input prices across north, south, east and west India. **VIJAY C ROY**

RBI rate-setting panel begins meet; decision on Wednesday

MINT

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) rate-setting panel on Monday started its three-day brainstorming session on the first bi-monthly monetary policy of the fiscal amid expectations of a status quo on the benchmark lending rate in view of apprehensions of a spike in inflation due to West Asia war. The decision of the six-member Monetary Policy Committee will be announced on Wednesday. **PTI**

GeM facilitates transactions worth ₹5.03 trillion in 2025-26

New Delhi: Public procurement platform Government e-Marketplace (GeM) facilitated transactions worth ₹5.03 trillion in 2025-26, down 7.4% from the previous fiscal, a senior official said on Monday. GeM facilitated transactions worth ₹5.43 trillion in 2024-25. GeM chief executive officer Mihir Kumar said the decline in growth can be attributed to a reduced contribution from the coal ministry, whose share in total sales fell from 34% to 20% in 2025-26. **PTI**

Central bank proposes tighter rules for bank agents

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India on Monday proposed tighter rules for bank agents delivering last-mile services in rural and underbanked regions, including stricter oversight, revised pay structures and stronger due diligence. The central bank outlined plans to reclassify and regulate business correspondents under two distinct models, enhance monitoring, and revise compensation structures. **REUTERS**

India's services sector slows as Iran war dents demand

Softer increases in sales were noted in three of the four broad areas of the service economy

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Despite growth slowing, the services sector saw a record increase in international orders, while input cost pressures remained at their most intense since mid-2022. AFP

India's services sector grew at its slowest pace in 14 months during March, mirroring the slowdown in the growth of new business intakes, as West Asia conflict hit domestic demand, a private survey showed on Monday.

The HSBC India Services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI), compiled by S&P Global, fell to 57.5 in March from 58.1 in February, marking the weakest rate of expansion in 14 months but remaining above its long-run average of 54.4.

Despite the slowdown in growth, the sector saw a record increase in international orders, while input cost pressures remained at their most intense since mid-2022. While new business gains continued to underpin growth, according to panellists, output was constrained by the detrimental impact of the West Asia war on demand, market conditions and tourism, the survey said.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Services PMI Business Activity Index is based on a single question: how the level of business activity compares with the previous month's. According to the survey, intakes of new work rose at the slowest pace since January 2025. Softer increases in sales were noted in three of the four broad areas of the service economy, namely finance and insurance, real estate & business services, and transport, information & communication.

58.9
The HSBC India Composite PMI Output Index in Feb

Conversely, all four categories recorded quicker expansions in new export orders, causing overall growth in foreign sales to approach a series peak. Since the introduction of this question in September 2014, a faster increase was noted only in June 2024. Panelists noted gains from Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe, the Americas and the Middle East, the survey said.

Pranjul Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC, said, "India's services sector stayed in expansion [mode] in March, but growth momentum eased for a second consecutive month. Demand remained resilient, led by new export orders, which rose to their highest since mid-2024. As such, service providers' expectations for future activity remained positive. However, input cost inflation accelerated to its fastest pace since 2022, indicating that higher fuel, transport and logistics costs are feeding into services."

57.0
The HSBC India Composite PMI Output Index in Mar

Of the four broad areas of the service economy monitored by the survey, the quickest increases in input costs and output charges were seen in consumer services and finance and insurance, respectively.

The latest report also showed a third consecutive monthly increase in employment. Moreover, the pace of job creation was the strongest since mid-2025 as an increase in business confidence boosted employment growth. Firms were at their most upbeat on the outlook for output in close to 12 years. This optimism was underpinned by hopes of an improvement in demand and market conditions, the survey said. Advertising and better customer relations were also expected to bear fruit.

The PMI data for March highlighted mild capacity pressures among services companies. This was evidenced by a marginal increase in outstanding business volumes—the third in as many months. The HSBC India Composite PMI Output Index also fell from 58.9 in February to 57.0 in March, marking the weakest rate of expansion in nearly three-and-a-half years. Service providers recorded a quicker upturn than manufacturers, though growth slowed in both cases. With new orders rising at softer rates among both goods producers and service providers, overall sales increased at the weakest pace since November 2023. The data showed the slowdown was centred on the domestic market as international demand for Indian goods and services grew at the fastest pace in seven months.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

India raises gas supply for fertilizer companies

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

India has increased the allocation of natural gas to urea plants as supply improves after disruptions due to the Middle East crisis, according to the oil ministry.

Overall gas supply to fertilizer plants has been raised to about 90% of their average consumption, from 70% to 75%, Sujata Sharma, a joint secretary in the ministry, told reporters in New Delhi on Monday.

India had faced supply constraints after liquefied natural gas shortages linked to the Iran war forced some urea manufacturers to shut their plants ahead of the monsoon planting season. LNG is a key raw material to produce the crop nutrient, and the nation is the world's largest importer of urea, a type of fertilizer.

The government made the decision to increase the gas allocation based on available inventory and scheduled LNG arrivals, as per an oil ministry statement on Sunday.

The nation is also looking to secure imports, with Indian Potash Ltd issuing a tender over the weekend to buy 2.5 million tonnes of urea. The world's largest urea importer purchases the crop nutrient through global tenders to meet demand. Sowing for rice, corn and soybeans is set to begin in a couple of months.

'Global economy in permanent volatility'

Harsh Kumar
harsh.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Trade fragmentation, along with the ongoing West Asia conflict, means that 2026 could prove more challenging, as the global economy moves from episodic "shocks" to a state of "permanent volatility," finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday.

However, India has sufficient fiscal space to sustain its asset-creating public expenditure, while the central bank has room to cut interest rates to support growth, aided by the government's commitment to fiscal prudence, she said.

Trade fragmentation has introduced severe uncertainty into global supply chains

"The escalation of the Middle East conflict has evolved from a regional security concern into a systemic tremor, threatening the vital arteries of global energy and hardening the lines of a new multipolar world order," Sitharaman said at an event organized by the National Institute of Public Finance and Policy (NIPFP), New Delhi.

The US and Israel launched coordinated strikes on Iran on 28 February, triggering retaliation that escalated into a wider regional conflict, with Tehran blocking access to the strategic Strait of Hormuz through which about a fifth of global oil trade passes.

Sitharaman said 2025 was monumental in more ways than initially expected. Trade fragmentation has introduced severe uncertainty into global supply chains. "This led to sharp downward revisions in global growth forecasts, but the year ended more optimistically than previously perceived, particularly for India," she added.

The finance minister noted that global public debt has surged to approximately $106 trillion, exceeding 95% of global gross domestic product.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

BofA cuts Indian cos' earnings estimates

Dipti Sharma
dipti.sharma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Despite rising optimism, Amish Shah, head of India research at BofA Global Research, remains unconvinced by the India outperformance story, expecting the country to lag its emerging-market (EM) peers and cutting his earnings growth estimates for Indian companies for the second time in a row.

Amish Shah, head of India research at BofA Global Research.

In an interview with *Mint*, he said crude prices have risen and that some energy infrastructure assets in West Asia have been affected by the war. Even if tensions ease, supplies are unlikely to return to pre-war levels soon, keeping prices elevated for longer. This is also expected to affect growth and keep commodity prices, including aluminium and copper, elevated.

Brent crude oil prices have shot up by over 42% since the war broke out at the end of February.

Given this, he saw little point in waiting for May earnings announcements and said the brokerage is instead building in more realistic estimates now to arrive at revised price targets.

"So, the first round of cuts we took was immediately after the conflict started. The conflict began on 27 February, and we cut our earnings on 2 March in anticipation that crude and commodities prices would spike. Now, with clear evidence that crude and commodity prices have already increased, we are incorporating that into our estimates and more accurately pricing in the impact, and that is why we have taken a second cut," he said.

Brent crude oil prices have shot up by over 42% since the war broke out at the end of February

The brokerage has cut its 2026-27 Nifty earnings growth further to 8.5% year-on-year, down from 11% in early March and 14% pre-war. "Consequently, we are now significantly below consensus at 15% on-year," BofA Securities' 6 April report said.

Shah said a prolonged war remains the biggest risk factor for equities, even now.

Since the war in West Asia began, the Nifty 50 and S&P BSE Sensex have slumped by around 9% each, while the Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 250 have fallen by 8% and 6%, respectively.

"If the conflict ends, there is scope for about a 15% upside from current levels. But if it drags on, there could be an 8% downside," he added.

That said, according to him, an end to this war could quickly turn the sentiment around and trigger an immediate rally in Indian equities.

A large part of the 15% rally will come after the war ends, he said, adding that "around 7% out of the 15% will come straight from valuation expansion immediately when the conflict ends, and the remaining 8% will be gradual through this calendar year".

Even if the conflict ends by the end of 2026, foreign flows are unlikely to turn meaningfully positive, though persistent outflows could ease, with some reversal, he said.

February was the only month that offered some respite in foreign flows, with foreign institutional investors (FIIs) briefly turning net buyers before resuming selling from March.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Government eyes biodegradable sachets to tackle plastic litter surge

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The government is working on an ambitious plan to encourage consumer goods makers to use biodegradable sachets to reduce plastic litter, curb soil pollution, and prevent drain blockages.

The department of consumer affairs' plan involves transitioning a wide range of sachet-based products to eco-friendly packaging by developing plastic-free, biodegradable alternatives for one of the most widely used packaging formats in the country, two people aware of the matter said.

"The plan involves engaging all stakeholders and encouraging them to adopt it step by step, starting with a few products on a pilot basis," said the first of the two persons cited earlier, both of whom spoke on the condition of anonymity.

"To start with, the ministry has planned to work towards replacing sachets used for pan masala and gutkha, which are a key contributor to littering in both urban and rural areas," said this person.

While their low cost have made plastic sachets a staple, the small packs also represent one of the largest sources of plastic litter.

While their low cost and convenience have made plastic sachets a staple, the small packs also represent one of the largest sources of plastic litter, as their size and multi-layered composition make them extremely difficult to collect and recycle.

This comes against the backdrop of India's ban on single-use plastic. The country generates around 3.5 million tonnes of plastic waste annually, according to the Central Pollution Control Board. Of this, around 40% is littered and remains uncollected.

Sachets are used across many product categories including personal care items such as shampoo, conditioner, hair oil, face wash, body wash, pan masala, gutkha, instant coffee, spices, sauces, dairy whitener, detergent powder, dishwashing liquid and floor cleaners.

Pan masala and gutkha are widely consumed across India and largely sold in small sachets (typically under 10 g). Designed for strength and shelf life, these sachets are among the highest-volume single-use packaging formats, with tens of billions produced annually.

"Manufacturers shifted to multi-layered paper-based laminates to comply, but these sachets remain non-biodegradable and difficult to collect or recycle due to their small size and mixed materials," the first person said, adding that many end up as litter in streets, drains, fields and water bodies. "The continued use of plastic-based adhesives, especially in the informal sector, further weakens the rules."

"This calls for biodegradable, plastic-free and scalable sachet alternatives for pan masala, gutkha and other consumer goods widely used in sachets."

Queries sent to the department of consumer affairs, and packaged goods makers such as Procter and Gamble, Hindustan Unilever and ITC remained unanswered.

A senior executive at a leading FMCG company said the transition is doable, but the key issue is how to manage the higher costs, as biodegradable sachets are more expensive than plastic ones. "We look forward to guidance from the ministry on developing cost-effective alternatives."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors.

Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to **feedback@livemint.com.**

It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about *Mint's* journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to **asktheeditor@livemint.com**

Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at **www.livemint.com**

FOR ANY QUERIES/DELIVERY ISSUES
CALL: 60004242, Monday-Saturday, 10am-6pm (Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Kolkata, Chennai, Hyderabad, Ahmedabad, Chandigarh, Pune and Lucknow) **MAIL: delivery@livemint.com TO SUBSCRIBE:** Give a missed call on **7039035039** or visit **www.mintreaders.com** or write to us at **subscription@livemint.com**

First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

RAVI KRISHNAN (EDITOR) - Responsible for selection of news under PRP Act, @ All rights reserved. Reproduction in whole or in part without written permission of Publisher is prohibited; PUBLISHED/PRINTED BY **MANHAR KAPOOR** ON BEHALF OF HT MEDIA LTD, 9th Floor, Tower 3, Indiabulls Finance Centre, Senapati Bapat Marg, Elphinstone Road (West), Mumbai-400013

Printed at HT Media Ltd. Press at Plot No. 6, TTC Industrial Area, Thane - Belapur Road, Navi Mumbai - 400 708.
RNI Registration MAHENG/2018/76720; Mint welcomes readers' responses to all articles and editorials. Please include your full name, address and telephone number. Send in your views to the editor at letters@livemint.com. ©2026 HT Media Ltd All Rights Reserved

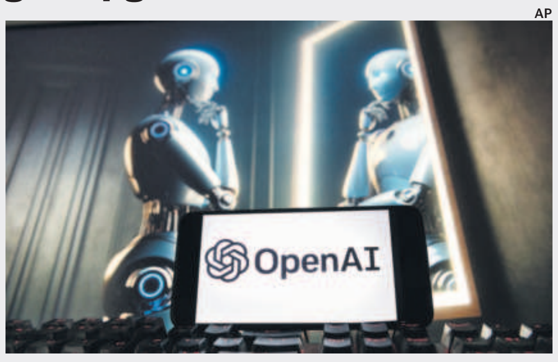
MINT SHORTS

Fashion brand Nykaa sees fastest quarterly revenue growth in 3 yrs

Bengaluru: Indian fashion-to-beauty retailer Nykaa said it expects net revenue to grow in the late-20% range in the fourth quarter of FY26, its fastest in three years, led by improved fashion sales and steady demand in beauty segment. Shares rose 3.9% to an over three-week high. The retailer said fourth-quarter consolidated net sales value is expected grow in the early-30% range, while consolidated gross merchandise value—the total monetary value of goods or services sold through the platform—is forecast to rise in the late-20% range. REUTERS

OpenAI proposes safety nets, grid upgrades for new AI era

AP



New York: OpenAI has released policy recommendations to navigate an era of artificial intelligence-fuelled upheaval, including creation of a public wealth fund, fast-response social safety net and speedier electrical grid development. In a document titled, *Industrial Policy for the Intelligence Age: Ideas to Keep People First*, OpenAI proposed policies related to AI "superintelligence"—referred to as software that can outperform humans in all tasks. BLOOMBERG

JIIF plans to invest ₹80-100 cr over 12-18 months in early-stage firms

New Delhi: Investment platform JITO Incubation and Innovation Foundation on Monday said it plans to invest ₹80-100 crore in early-stage startups over the next 12-18 months. The platform has invested over ₹150 crore across more than 100 pre-seed and seed-stage startups over the past two years, and reported over 15 exits during the period. PTI

UAE's Valura.ai makes India debut, onboards 1,000 wealth advisors

New Delhi: Valura.ai, an AI-native global investment platform, announced the onboarding of over 1,000 wealth advisors across India ahead of its official launch, with a collective AUM pipeline exceeding ₹3,000 crore in 12-18 months. It provides access to over 100,000 global securities with client assets held in local custody within IFSC at GIFT City under IFSCA regulation. PTI

Serum Institute, Trivitron in talks to take MyLab global

Firms to set up MyLab Trivitron Next Gen Technologies to boost investments and expansion

Priyamvada C & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Adar Poonawalla-led Serum Institute of India Pvt. Ltd is in talks to partner with medical device maker Trivitron Healthcare to scale up its investment in MyLab Discovery Solutions Pvt. Ltd and expand the Pune-based diagnostics provider's operations internationally, said three people familiar with the matter.

Chandra Ganjoo, group chief executive officer at Trivitron; and Gurinder Bir Kaur, associate vice president of human resources, have been listed as directors on the board of a new joint venture, Mylab Trivitron Next Gen Technologies, according to a legal filing sourced by Tracxn.

The deal is in advanced stages of due diligence, and the final contours of the transaction are yet to be decided, said two of the three people quoted earlier.

"A separate entity has been created to get rid of MyLab's debt and facilitate the investment," a third person said—all three spoke on the condition of anonymity as details are not public yet.

"Other strategics were approached for a JV, but MyLab is going with Trivitron as the two have complementary synergies and the talks have actively progressed over the last two months," the person said, adding that a deal is expected to be signed over the next few days.

Mylab founder Hasmukh Rawal confirmed to *Mint* in an emailed statement, "We are structuring the JV with Trivitron for better International opportunities in distribution and manufacturing with their global reach and presence, with a focus on high-end technologies of Mylab."

Both Trivitron and Serum Institute declined to comment

The JV between Adar Poonawalla-led firm and Trivitron Healthcare will look to expand MyLab's global distribution and manufacturing. MINT

Mylab will benefit from Trivitron's manufacturing capabilities to bolster its presence in the in-vitro diagnostics (IVD) and molecular diagnostics in India and overseas markets. The joint venture plans to leverage Trivitron's promoter Dr. G.S.K. Velu's three decades of experience in the healthcare industry in scaling hospital and diagnostics chains.

Velu, a first-generation entrepreneur, managed many diagnostic chains and hospitals, in addition to manufacturing and trading medical devices. He has backed and held key positions in Neuberg Diagnostics, Maxivision Eye Hospitals, Apollo Dialysis and Sri Kauvery Medical Care Trichy.

Set up in 2016 by Rawal and Shailendra Kawade, Mylab is a molecular diagnostic firm which develops and sells diagnostic kits used in human diagnostics, food safety, agriculture, and veterinary medicine. It offers a cost-effective solutions for early detection and monitoring of a range of ailments, including covid-19, tuberculosis, cancer, genetic disorders, and diseases caused by parasitic, viral, or bacterial infections.

The Poonawalla group holds 49% stake in the firm. Dr Cyrus Poonawalla, promoter, Serum Institute of India, has 10% stake in Mylab in personal capacity, while 32.50% is held by Poonawalla group firm Rising Sun Holdings Pvt. Ltd—which, according to a CareEdge ratings report of May 2025, is controlled by Adar Poonawalla.

Mylab's income and operating margin fell post-covid. Its income slid from about ₹825 crore in FY21 to around ₹94 crore in FY23. However, the company has been gradually recovering, reporting an operating revenue of ₹147 crore in FY24 with a profit of ₹1.8 crore, according to data sourced by Tofler from the ministry of corporate affairs.

Meanwhile, Chennai-based Trivitron group trades in and manufactures medical equipment, devices, and consumables. Established by Velu in 1998, the group has floated several joint ventures with leading global medical equipment manufacturers and healthcare service providers. It has a diversified product profile comprising C-arm/X-ray scans, ultrasound, newborn screening, radiation protection apparel, surgical imaging, and ICU products, among others.

Trivitron manufactures around 50% of its products, while the remaining are imported and resold in the domestic market. The company also has a presence in Turkey, Finland, the US, and China. About 57% of its consolidated revenues are derived from Asian entities (including India), while the remaining come from other overseas markets, Icra Ltd said in a report in July last year.

priyamvada.c@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

DIAGNOSTICS PLAY

DEAL is in advanced due diligence phase, and final transaction details are yet to be decided, people said

THE new entity has been created to clean up MyLab's debt and facilitate fresh investments

MYLAB to leverage Trivitron's global network to grow its in-vitro, molecular diagnostics presence

MYLAB'S revenue fell after pandemic, from about ₹825 cr in FY21 to around ₹94 cr in FY23

E-bike firm Matter eyes $50 mn in fresh round

Agnidev Bhattacharya
agnidev.bhattacharya@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Electric motorcycle manufacturer Matter Motor Works is seeking to raise fresh capital in a Series C funding round. This could value the company at around $300 million post-money, two people in the know told *Mint*.

Co-founder Mohal Lalbhai confirmed the fundraise, saying the company is in discussions with existing and new investors to support market expansion this financial year, but declined to comment on valuation. "We are in the process of raising around $50 million from existing and new investors as we look to grow our market presence over this financial year," he said.

The round is being led by existing investors, including Capital 2B, and Japan Airlines' JAL Innovation Fund, one of the two people quoted above said on the condition of anonymity. Capital 2B is a tech and venture fund that operates with financial backing from Singapore's state-owned investment firm Temasek Holdings Pte and Sanjeev Bikhchandani's Info Edge. The round is likely to close within three months.

The fundraising comes as India's electric motorcycle segment struggles to gain traction despite policy support and investor interest. Electric motorbikes contributed less than 1% of the 1.14 million battery-powered two-wheelers sold during FY25, according to a report by government think tank Niti Aayog.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Wipro secures $1 billion contract from Singapore's Olam Group

Jas Bardia
jas.bardia@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Wipro Ltd has bagged a $1 billion, eight-year contract from Singapore-headquartered food processing major Olam Group, marking its first mega deal in nearly six years.

As part of a broader engagement, India's fourth-largest information technology (IT) services provider will acquire Mindsprint, Olam's IT arm, for $375 million in an all-cash deal, it said in a release to the stock exchanges on Monday.

Following the announcement, Wipro's shares opened 3.6% higher at ₹198.4 on the BSE in a largely weak market.

The Bengaluru-based firm will manage the food processing company's end-to-end IT transformation services. Olam committed to spend at least $800 million over eight years in modernising its IT systems with an option to spend more than $1 billion in total.

Avendus Capital was the exclusive financial advisor to Olam Group and Mindsprint on this transaction.

As part of the agreement, Wipro will acquire Olam's IT business Mindsprint for $375 million in an all-cash transaction. MINT

Mindsprint ended last year with $136 million in revenue and the acquisition is likely to close by June, subject to regulatory approvals. The company has about 3,200 people and specialises in providing IT services to food and agri-business companies with its proprietary IP-driven solutions.

Starting FY27, Wipro would make $136 million from the Mindsprint acquisition and at least $100 million annually in the following years. Most of Mindsprint's business comes from parent Olam, according to a person with knowledge of the matter.

This translates into 1.3% of Wipro's FY25 revenue in first year and at least 1% for remaining seven years. It ended last year with $10.51 billion in revenue, down 2.7% from a year earlier. "We will now aim to bid for more deals in the agri-business industry as we have access to Mindsprint's IP," said a person with knowledge of the matter on condition of anonymity.

The deal also comes at a time when Wipro is staring at the possibility of a third straight year of revenue decline amid an uncertain macroeconomic environment due to the west asia war.

Wipro posted $7.83 billion in revenue for the first nine months of FY26 and needs 1.86% sequential growth in the January-March period to match last year's revenue. This would mark its strongest fourth quarter in four years.

In January, its management had expected fourth-quarter revenue of $2.64-2.69 billion, which implies a full-year revenue decline at the lower end of the range.

At least one expert said this deal was similar to those structured in the past, where large IT services companies would acquire smaller firms and then bag big-ticket IT servicing contracts from them.

"This is a classic 'acquire captive and get contract' deal and it is reminiscent of the past when such contracts were common. Mindsprint brings deep agri-domain IP including Farmsprint, Procuresprint & Tradesprint platforms to Wipro," said Sushovon Nayak, lead IT analyst at Anand Rathi Institutional Equities.

Wipro to manage end-to-end IT transformation; Olam committed to spending at least $800 mn over eight years

Wipro is not new to such deals. In September 2018, the company won its largest IT outsourcing contract, valued at $1.6 billion over 10 years from Alight Solutions LLC, which is the former benefits administration and human-resources outsourcing business of Aon Plc. As part of the deal stitched under chief executive Abidali Neemuchwala, Wipro had acquired Alight's IT arm.

Significantly, its last mega deal was also structured like the current one. In December 2020, Wipro clinched an IT transformation contract with German food wholesaler, Metro AG. This guaranteed Wipro $700 million for the first five years, with an option to extend the deal up to four additional years with potential revenue of up to $1 billion.

Other IT outsourcers have also bagged such deals in the past. TCS acquired Citigroup Global Services in 2008 for $505 million. It also won an IT outsourcing contract worth $2.5 billion from the financial institution over nine years. In the same year, WNS acquired Aviva's offshore captive for around $228 million, backed by an IT deal worth $1 billion over eight years.

Wipro's management said the deal would increase its footprint in the food and agri-business industry.

"Wipro's strategic engagement with Olam Group is an important step in expanding our farm-to-fork capabilities and scaling the impact of Wipro Intelligence™ across the food and agri-business industry," said Srini Pallia, chief executive officer of Wipro, as part of the company's release.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

It raised capital from family offices, UHNWs and global investors, says Saurabh Jhalaria, CIO, private credit, InCred Alternatives.

InCred Alt secures ₹1,500 crore for its maiden credit fund

Priyamvada C
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

InCred Alternatives has closed its maiden special opportunities credit fund with a corpus of ₹1,500 crore, joining a growing wave of investment firms entering India's expanding private credit market.

"India's private credit market is at an early but decisive stage of institutionalization and is very different from the private credit market in the West," Saurabh Jhalaria, chief investment officer–private credit at InCred Alternatives, said in a statement on Tuesday. "Supply gap is large and the risk-reward potential is compelling," he said.

The special opportunities credit fund has raised capital from domestic family offices, ultra-high-net-worth individuals as well as international investors across markets.

About 75% of the fund has already been deployed across sectors such as auto, power, oil & gas, and hospitality. The fund primarily focuses on old-economy businesses with hard asset coverage, established cash flows and clear structural downside protection built in at the time of investment.

InCred Alternatives has so far raised over ₹4,000 crore across its performing credit funds and special situation funds. Both global and domestic investment firms have been increasingly entering the space as companies seek faster and more flexible capital than traditional lenders can typically provide.

InCred Group's founder Bhupinder Singh said the alternatives arm, launched in 2022, has built a track record in origination, underwriting, active portfolio management, and income distribution.

About 75% of the fund has already been deployed across sectors such as power, oil and gas, auto, and hospitality

Over the past 12 to 18 months, firms including DMI Alternatives, Ascertis Credit, Motilal Oswal Alternates, ASK Group, True North, Edelweiss, Multiples Alternate Asset Management, Prabhudas Lilladhar, 360 One Asset and Vivriti Asset Management have launched new funds in the private credit space.

Global heavyweight Blackstone Group and Bandhan AMC are also setting up dedicated platforms in this segment. The National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) has announced a $2 billion plan to attract global capital into the asset class in India.

Gulf funds agree to back Paramount's $81 bn Warner takeover

Jessica Toonkel & Lauren Thomas

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Paramount has received signed equity commitments of close to $24 billion from three sovereign-wealth funds led by Saudi Arabia to help back its takeover of Warner Bros. Discovery, according to people familiar with the matter.

Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund has agreed to provide roughly $10 billion of the nearly $24 billion to Paramount, run by David Ellison, the son of billionaire Oracle co-founder Larry Ellison.

The agreements with investors also include Qatar Investment Authority and Abu Dhabi's L'imad Holding Co., the people said.

The agreements by the Middle East funds coincide with the region's increased economic and political unrest caused by the U.S. and Israel's war with Iran. In February, Paramount announced its deal to buy Warner Discovery, home to HBO, CNN and Harry Potter, for $81 billion. The deal is pending regulatory review in Europe, and Paramount executives have told employees to prepare to close as soon as the end of July, according to other people familiar with the situation.

The commitments by the Gulf investors will help offset the cost for the Ellisons and RedBird Capital Partners, which is also backing the deal.

Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund agreed to provide roughly $10 billion of the nearly $24 billion to Paramount for the deal. AP

As part of its deal, Paramount has said any equity syndication wouldn't affect the transaction closing because the Ellison family would cover the entire amount if needed.

The Gulf investors won't have voting rights in the new Paramount-Warner entity, and the deal isn't expected to trigger a mandatory review by the Committee on Foreign Investment in the U.S., or Cfius, people familiar with the matter said. Because each entity will own far less than 25% of the combined company, executives don't expect the funds' involvement to spark a review by the Federal Communications Commission either, the people said.

Paramount had previously disclosed that three sovereign-wealth funds had committed to contribute about $24 billion to its bid. Paramount launched a hostile bid for Warner, which had opted to sign a deal to sell to Netflix instead. After months of jockeying, Paramount emerged victorious when it sweetened its offer for Warner, defeating Netflix.

Paramount has said any equity syndication won't affect the deal closing, as Ellison family will cover required amount

An early version of Paramount's bid also initially included backing from Chinese company Tencent and Affinity Partners, the private-equity firm founded by President Trump 's son-in-law Jared Kushner . Affinity later backed out of Paramount's deal. Tencent is also no longer in the deal, the people said.

Paramount has also received $54 billion of debt commitments from Bank of America, Citigroup and the private-equity firm Apollo Global Management, which it is beginning to syndicate out to other banks and investors. Paramount's deal for Warner is valued at $110 billion including debt.

feedback@livemint.com

	BSE Sensex	Nifty 50	Nifty 500	Nifty Next 50	Nifty 100	BSE 150 MidCap	BSE 250 SmallCap
Close	74,106.85	22,968.25	21,194.05	62,858.95	23,579.45	14,756.04	5,908.13
Percent change	1.07	1.12	1.22	1.45	1.18	1.30	1.10
Previous close	73,319.55	22,713.10	20,938.35	61,957.60	23,304.20	14,567.37	5,843.57
Open	73,477.53	22,780.30	20,990.85	62,198.05	23,376.90	14,603.47	5,854.58
High	74,207.46	22,998.35	21,217.95	62,932.35	23,609.25	14,767.89	5,912.18
Low	72,728.66	22,542.95	20,789.45	61,586.80	23,159.75	14,403.40	5,776.57

Marico steady amid uncertainty

Pallavi Pengonda
pallavi.pengonda@livemint.com

The humble coconut has emerged as an unlikely buffer for Marico Ltd, even as war-led disruption and cost pressures are set to lash its fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) peers. The Nifty FMCG index is down 16% so far in 2026, while Marico's stock has been largely flat. The key driver: copra prices. The commodity, a core input for the maker of Parachute hair oil, has fallen about 35% from its peak and is expected to remain range-bound in the months ahead, Marico has said.

That decline offers Marico a cushion against input inflation triggered by the West Asia conflict, giving it relatively stronger earnings visibility than peers. Copra accounts for roughly half of Marico's raw material basket, according to Motilal Oswal Financial Services. Further, crude derivatives (including packaging) form 18-20% of total raw materials, implying a lower impact than that faced by Marico's peers, said the brokerage.

In its March quarter (Q4FY26) business update, Marico said it expects its gross margin to increase sequentially, thanks to easing copra prices. This would mark a second straight quarterly improvement after margins recovered to 43.5% in Q3 from a multi-quarter low of 42.6% in Q2. JM Financial Institutional Securities estimates Marico's Q4 gross margin at 44.8%, though lower from the 48.6% seen in Q4FY25.

Continued brand building investments would mean double-digit year-on-year growth in Ebitda in Q4. JM Financial expects 15% Ebitda year-on-year growth in Q4. Ebitda had increased 7.5% year-on-year in the nine-month ended December (9MFY26).

"Marico also has other margin levers (margin expansion in foods/D2C and improving growth in VAHO), which will drive overall earnings trajectory over FY27/28E," said JM's analysts in a report on 2 April.

Marico said its consolidated revenue for Q4 grew year-on-year in early 20s, enabling it to meet FY26 aspiration of mid-20s revenue growth. The India business delivered high single-digit underlying volume growth, while the Parachute franchise saw selective price cuts to pass on the benefit of lower copra costs. Value-added hair oils (VAHO) grew in the 20s and the company expects double-digit VAHO growth in FY27 and over the medium term, aided by the mid and premium segments, enhanced direct reach through project SETU, and better affordability after the goods and services tax (GST) cuts.

Foods business delivered high-teens value growth in Q4. The premium personal care, including digital-first brands, business beat expectations. The international business (about 25% of revenues) saw high-teens constant currency growth; each market contributed positively, except the Gulf region impacted by the war.

Marico's valuations aren't exactly cheap. The stock trades at 46 times estimated earnings for FY27, as per *Bloomberg* consensus. Marico is confident of delivering healthy volume-led revenue growth in FY27.

Execution will be key from here. "We expect commencement of price cuts in Parachute due to falling copra prices to moderate Marico's overall sales growth going forward but lead to margin improvement and double-digit to mid-teens operating profit growth," said Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India).

Any slowdown in foods or premium personal care could temper investor sentiment.

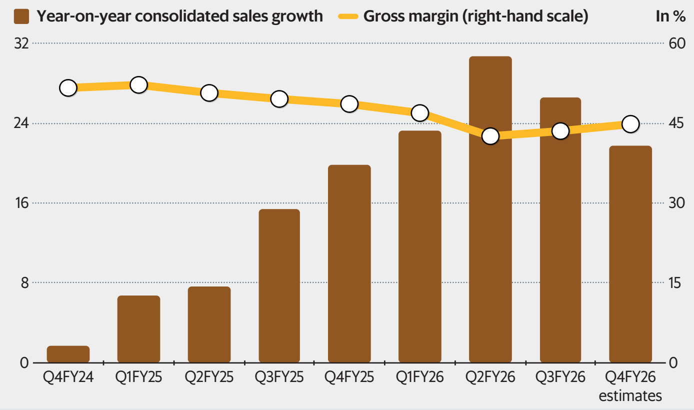
SALES DRIVE

MARICO'S Q4 revenue grew y-o-y in low-20s, helping it clock FY26 revenue growth of mid-20s

THE company is confident of delivering healthy volume-led revenue growth in FY27

Earnings boost

Marico's gross margin is seen rising q-o-q in Q4FY26, but year-on-year revenue growth would be lower than Q3.



Source: Company, JM Financial

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Sobha sees record pre-sales in FY26. Is there room for growth?

Harsha Jethmalani
harsha.j@livemint.com

After reporting a pre-sales drop in FY25, realty firm Sobha Ltd exited FY26 with a bang. Pre-sales or bookings rose 30% year-on-year to ₹8,136 crore—its best-ever, driven by new launches and geographical diversification. Still, it missed the ₹8,500 crore pre-sales target set for the fiscal year.

Sobha launched nine projects in six cities during FY26. Of these, three were in the March quarter (Q4FY26); pre-sales for Q4 rose year-on-year to ₹2,039 crore. Sobha made its foray in Mumbai and Greater Noida in FY26.

On the flip side, Gurugram project (Sector 63A) has spilled over to FY27 due to delay in RERA approval. Had it been launched as planned, FY26 pre-sales would have touched ₹8,500-9,000 crore, said Antique Stock Broking.

Sobha's bookings growth driver remains one crucial market- IT hub Bengaluru. This market recorded its highest-ever pre-sales of ₹4,478 crore in FY26, contributing 55% to total pre-sales. Strong traction across all projects aided the momentum.

The National Capital Region clocked pre-sales of ₹2,455 crore, accounting for 30% of total pre-sales. Sobha launched two new residential projects in Greater Noida and one serviced residences project in Gurugram during the year. Kerala contributed 10% to pre-sales, supported by new towers launched in Marina One, Cochin and a new project launch in Trivandrum. All other cities contributed 5% of total sales.

Sobha sold around 5.5 million square feet of space in FY26, up 18.5% year-on-year; average realisation rose 9% year-on-year to ₹14,675 per square feet. Despite these positives and a healthy balance sheet, the mood is sombre. The Sobha stock is down 16% so far in 2026, versus 23% fall in the Nifty Realty index. Investor sentiment has turned sour for all realty stocks.

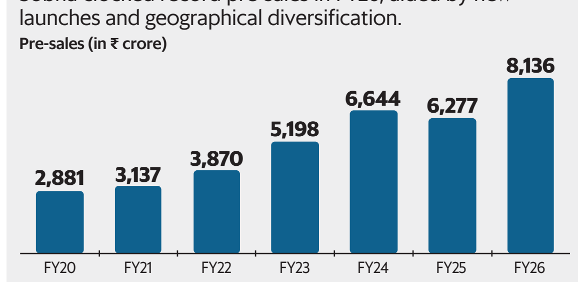
An AI-led disruption and West Asia war fuelling inflation are seen as potential dampeners to demand, especially in the mid-income/premium segments.

"While Bengaluru can deliver volume growth, threat of job losses due to AI and the ongoing war have led to a decline in housing sales in the country and increased risk perception of realty stocks," said Nuvama Research report on 5 April.

Sobha also has exposure to Pune, a key IT market. In this backdrop, the pace of new launches and customer response to them will determine the stock's trajectory.

Flying high

Sobha clocked record pre-sales in FY26, aided by new launches and geographical diversification.



Source: Company

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Sebi eyes initiative to bolster board independence

Apoorva Ajith
apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Sebi chief said building capacity was crucial.

India's market regulator is working on a collaborative framework with corporates, academia and professional bodies to expand the pipeline and effectiveness of independent directors, even as recent boardroom tensions at HDFC Bank sharpen scrutiny on governance standards.

"Sebi will seek to embark on a joint initiative for capacity building of independent directors at scale with a view to further improve corporate governance," Sebi chief Tuhin Kanta Pandey said at the 19th Governance Summit hosted by the Confederation of Indian industries (CII) on Monday.

"Boards are well constituted, but not always equally effective. Information is available but not always interrogated deeply. Independence exists in form, but may not always translate into an independent perspective," he added.

The proposed initiative, still taking shape, will bring together industry, academic institutions and professional bodies to expand both the supply and capabilities of independent directors.

Pandey said the goal is no longer formal compliance but depth and effectiveness.

The push comes at a time when boardroom dynamics are under scrutiny following the abrupt resignation of Atanu Chakraborty as non-executive chairman and independent director of HDFC Bank. Chakraborty stepped down in March citing "certain happenings and practices" that were not aligned with his personal values and ethics, triggering questions about how dissent is expressed and recorded within boards.

Sebi chief Tuhin Kanta Pandey said the goal is no longer formal compliance but depth and effectiveness

The Sebi chairman, following the regulator's board meeting in March, said it was important for independent directors to elaborate on their concerns, if any, in company board meetings rather than leaving their positions ambiguous.

Chakraborty, who joined the bank's board in 2021 and oversaw its merger with HDFC Ltd, later indicated that the alleged mis-selling of Credit Suisse's perpetual bonds may have been a point of disagreement with management.

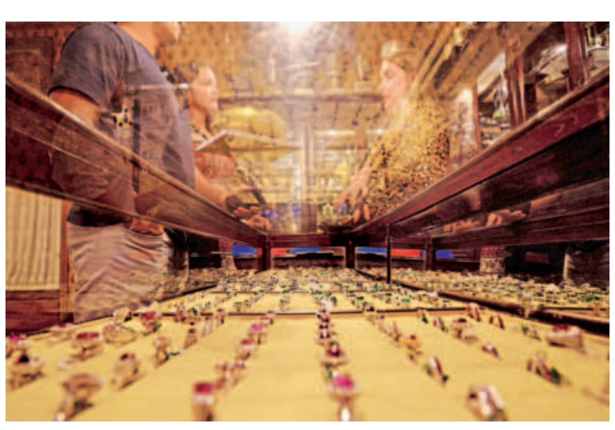
While he refrained from divulging detailed boardroom discussions, the episode renewed the debate over how effectively independent directors can challenge management decisions in complex, high-stakes environments.

Pandey said building capacity was crucial for improving this framework.

"Capacity building cannot be mandated in a prescriptive manner. But it can certainly be encouraged, enabled and supported through collaboration between regulators, industry bodies, professional bodies and academic business institutions," he said.

Titan turns to coloured gems to boost entry-level jewellery

Vaeshnavi Kasthuril
k.vaeshnavi@livemint.com
BENGALURU



Using over 17 gemstone varieties, the collection aims to be more accessible for younger consumers. MINT

India's top organized jeweller Titan Co Ltd is betting on coloured gemstones to buoy entry-level demand, as volatile gold prices hurt affordability.

The Bengaluru-based firm has launched 'Hues', a range of coloured gemstone jewellery under its flagship Tanishq label. The collection features over 200 designs crafted from natural stones such as amethyst, tanzanite and tourmaline. Using over 17 gemstone varieties, the collection aims to be more accessible for younger consumers and is priced in the ₹40,000-2.5 lakh range. Nearly 70% of the collection carries a sub-₹2.5 lakh tag.

India's jewellery demand remains anchored in weddings and festivals, but it's increasingly being reshaped by millennials, who are keen on light-weight designs, gemstone-led fusion pieces and craftsmanship.

The company already offered coloured gemstone jewellery, largely rooted in traditional designs. With 'Hues', it is pivoting towards more contemporary design pieces in 18-karat gold.

"There has been a clear rise in consumer interest in gemstones over the last few years," said Arun Narayan, chief executive officer of Titan's jewellery division in an interview with *Mint*. "While coloured stones have always been part of traditional jewellery, the category remains underexplored, and we see an opportunity to bring something new to consumers."

Jewellery demand remains anchored in weddings and festivals, but it's increasingly being reshaped by millennials

Industry executives say the shift is being driven by changing consumer preferences.

"Over the past few years, we've seen a clear move towards coloured gemstones, particularly as consumers explore alternatives beyond diamonds," said D.P. Khandelwal, convenor of the coloured gemstones panel of the Gem and Jewellery Export Promotion Council. "Rarer gemstones tend to hold and even appreciate in value, which is also attracting investor interest."

Rising gold prices are weighing on demand in lower-priced segments across the industry. While higher-ticket purchases gain traction, entry-level growth has slowed, pointing to affordability pressures and a shift toward premiumization.

The launch comes ahead of Akshaya Tritiya, an auspicious period for jewellery buying.

"Our latest consumer sentiment study gives us reason to be optimistic ahead of Akshaya Tritiya. Interest in buying jewellery remains high across all segments, like investment buyers, value seekers and design-led consumers," said Narayan. "With a favourable wedding season ahead and some cooling in gold prices, we expect an advancement of purchases, and overall, the factors leave us feeling positive about demand."

Titan's move coincides with slower store additions for its Damas Jewellery business in the Gulf region amid the West Asia war.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Amfi backs intraday loans as Sebi defers rules

Apoorva Ajith
apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

India's mutual fund body has asked the market regulator to allow fund houses to use intraday borrowings from banks to purchase securities after it deferred implementation of the new norms to July, according to two people aware of the development.

On 13 March, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) tightened regulations and allowed fund houses to borrow funds from banks on an intraday basis only for repurchase or redemption of units, payment of interest, or income distribution-cum-capital withdrawal payouts to unitholders. The rules were set to roll out on 1 April, said a Sebi circular.

"The circular will tie up mutual funds' hands. Mutual funds have told the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi) and Amfi is talking to Sebi about this," one person said.

Sebi permitted such borrowing without an upper limit on the condition that it is backed by guaranteed same-day receivables from maturity proceeds of government securities.

On March 25, Sebi deferred the implementation of the rules to 15 July, citing "operational challenges" raised by asset management companies.

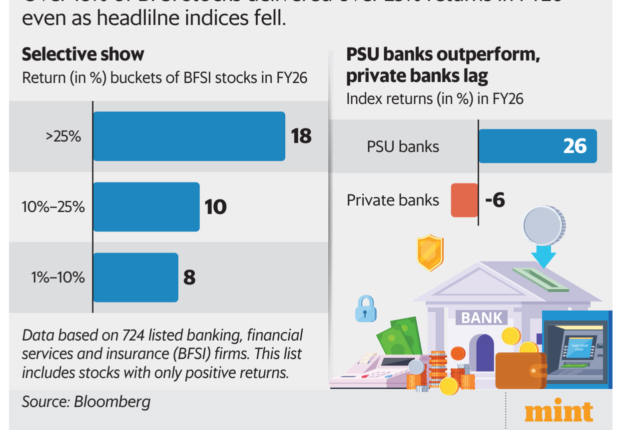
For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Stock-pickers gain in muted year for BFSI

Mayur Bhalerao
mayur.bhalerao@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Wide divergence

Over 18% of BFSI stocks delivered over 25% returns in FY26 even as headline indices fell.



Data based on 724 listed banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI) firms. This list includes stocks with only positive returns.

Source: Bloomberg

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

India's banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI) sector may have had a muted year on the surface, but a closer look tells a very different story. FY26, marked by global uncertainty, earnings downgrades and foreign investor outflows, did not reward broad sector bets—but it strongly rewarded stock-pickers.

A *Mint* analysis of 724 BFSI stocks shows that nearly one in five companies delivered strong gains despite weak benchmark performance. As many as 131 stocks, or over 18% of the universe, generated returns of more than 25% during the year. This stands in contrast to headline indices such as the Nifty Bank and Nifty Financial Services, which fell about 2.5% and 6.2%, respectively, and remained under pressure for most of FY26.

The divergence highlights a shift in market behaviour from sector-driven rallies to company-specific performance. The list of outperformers reflects this trend. MCX surged 124%, LKP Finance gained 112%, while RBL Bank and L&T Finance rose 67% and 57%, respectively. These gains were driven by individual factors such as earnings recovery, improving asset quality or business-specific triggers, rather than any broad-based sector tailwind.

The broader distribution of returns reinforces this shift. Around 10% of BFSI stocks delivered moderate gains between 10% and 25%, while another 8% posted returns in the 1–10% range. This means that more than a third of the sector ended FY26 with positive returns, despite a challenging macro environment.

At the same time, losses were equally widespread. About 34% of stocks declined by up to 25%, while 16% fell between 10% and 25%. Nearly 8% of companies posted marginal declines of up to 10%. This wide dispersion shows that FY26 was not about whether to invest in BFSI, but where within the sector to invest. Stock selection mattered more than ever.

One of the defining trends of FY26 was the sharp divergence between PSU and private sector banks

Market capitalization of the BFSI universe saw some erosion, falling to ₹94.6 trillion in FY26 from ₹96.3 trillion in the previous year, reflecting the broader pressure on valuations.

The underlying performance of the BFSI sector remained relatively strong. In Q3FY26, the sector emerged as one of the best performers within India Inc. Revenue grew 14.5% year-on-year—the fastest pace in six quarters—while profit growth remained equally strong, supported by steady credit growth and easing credit costs. This pushed BFSI's share in India Inc.'s overall profit pool to a three-year high.

In comparison, a *Mint* analysis of 3,905 companies shows that India Inc.'s revenue grew 10% year-on-year during the period—the fastest in seven quarters—but profit growth lagged at 11%, the slowest pace in five quarters.

Despite this relative strength, BFSI stocks did not see a similar re-rating in the market. The Nifty Financial index declined 6.2% in FY26, while the Nifty Bank index fell 2.5%, compared with a 5.1% drop in the benchmark Nifty 50.

The disconnect reflects pressure from valuations, earnings downgrades in select pockets and persistent selling by foreign investors. Foreign portfolio investors sold nearly ₹29,242 crore worth of financial stocks during FY26, according to NSDL data. This continuous outflow weighed heavily on large-cap financial stocks.

One of the defining trends of FY26 was the sharp divergence between PSU and private sector banks. Public sector banks emerged as clear outperformers. The Nifty PSU Bank index gained about 26% during the year, supported by improving balance sheets, better asset quality and earnings upgrades. Stocks such as Indian Bank rose 56%, Canara Bank gained 39%, and Bank of Maharashtra advanced 32%.

In contrast, private sector banks had a weaker year. The Nifty Private Bank index declined around 6%.

"Would rather say weak for private banks as they struggled with credit growth and low deposit mobilisation, which also pulled down valuation premium gap between their PSU peers," said Narendra Solanki, head fundamental research-investment services, Anand Rathi Shares and Stock Brokers. "Broadly, the year has turned out to be a year of stock-specific alpha due to prevailing global uncertainties and tariff woes, where individual companies had different sector exposure mix, driving respective gains."

For an extended version of this story, visit livemint.com

Vedanta fails to stall Adani's JAL plan at SC

However, SC mandated NCLAT approval for any major policy decisions

Krishna Yadav & Yash Tiwari
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Apex court declined to interfere with orders of National Company Law Tribunal and the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal that cleared Adani's resolution plan.. REUTERS

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to stay the implementation of Adani Enterprises Ltd's ₹14,543 crore resolution plan for bankrupt Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL), rejecting a challenge by mining major Vedanta Ltd.

A bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi declined to interfere with orders of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) and the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), which had cleared the way for the plan's rollout.

However, the court directed the panel overseeing the resolution to seek prior NCLAT approval before taking any major steps and asked the appellate tribunal to hear the matter expeditiously. NCLAT is scheduled to hear the case on 10 April.

Vedanta, the losing bidder, challenged the lenders' approval of Adani's plan, and alleged that its higher offer was ignored and the process lacked fairness and transparency. The petition before the top court followed failed challenges at both NCLT and the NCLAT. On 24 March, the appellate tribunal declined to offer any interim relief, allowing Adani to proceed with its plan, subject to the outcome of the appeal.

It refused to halt the delisting of Jaiprakash Associates, citing Committee of Creditors' (CoC) submission that if the resolution plan is later set aside, all actions taken under it, including the delisting, would automatically stand reversed.

During Monday's hearing, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Vedanta, argued that its ₹17,926-crore bid was higher than Adani's and offered better value to creditors, yet the lenders chose Adani's plan, effectively accepting about ₹3,000 crore lower value. He said that once the plan is implemented and over 15,000 creditors are paid, reversing the process, including the company's delisting, would be difficult.

"I want the matter to be heard; in the meantime, nothing should be done. Once the deal is implemented, it would be impossible to unscramble. We want to buy Formula One (circuit), the Formula One also with Jaypee, along with several other assets. All 15,000 creditors will be paid and gone—how will we get it back?" Sibal remarked.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who appeared for CoC, countered that nothing irreversible would happen immediately, as implementation, including delisting, is a stepwise process that would take at least 50 days. He said the difference between bids was about ₹500 crore and Adani's plan was superior on merits, particularly in terms of faster upfront payments.

"Initially, Adani Enterprises) and the number of days in which upfront payment is made is better; the difference is 500, it's not, my lord, the difference is double — that is the impression being created," Mehta remarked.

"We respect the Hon'ble Supreme Court's order directing the JAL monitoring committee to seek NCLAT's approval before any major policy decisions and directing the NCLAT to hear Vedanta's plea on priority," Vedanta said in an emailed response to Mint's query.

Queries emailed to Adani Enterprises remained unanswered till press time.

At the heart of the dispute is how value should be assessed under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code. Vedanta has argued that lenders violated the principle of maximising value through a fair and transparent process. It said it emerged as the highest bidder during the challenge process, with an offer of ₹12,505.85 crore on a net present value basis.

krishna.yadav@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

BID BATTLE

NCLAT WAS asked to hear the dispute expeditiously, and the next hearing is slated for 10 April

VEDANTA had challenged lenders' approval of Adani's plan, alleging lack of transparency

THE SC also refused to halt the proposed JAL delisting, citing CoC's view that the steps are reversible

JSW Group pumps ₹2,600 cr in auto arm ahead of launch

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI


The Sajjan Jindal-led group company will focus on clean mobility technologies such as electric vehicles and hybrids. MINT

Billionaire Sajjan Jindal-led JSW Group has so far infused about ₹2,600 crore into its automobile subsidiary, JSW Green Mobility, since inception—signalling a serious push into India's passenger and commercial vehicle market as it gears up for a FY27 debut.

According to *Mint*'s review of multiple filings with the ministry of corporate affairs, the capital was deployed primarily toward setting up plant operations for passenger and commercial vehicle businesses in Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, alongside general corporate purposes and debt repayment.

With interests spanning steel, energy and paints, JSW's move marks its most decisive diversification yet—and places it alongside Tata Group and Mahindra as the third major Indian business house entering the automobile sector.

While the automobile arm was incorporated in 2023, filings show it didn't get meaningful financial support from group firms until December 2024—when chairman Jindal declared JSW's intent to build its own automobile brand.

Funding from group firms accelerated sharply after that announcement. Queries to JSW Group went unanswered.

"Our idea is not to be an outpost of a Chinese company to sell products in India," Jindal told the *Financial Times* in December 2024. "We want to manufacture the products in India, value-add in India, and sell them in India."

It is scheduled to launch its first car in October–December 2026. The launch timeline for commercial vehicles (CV) remains unclear. Investments into JSW Green Mobility are separate from the group's investment in JSW MG Motor India, a JV with China's SAIC.

JSW's foray will centre on clean fuel technologies such as electric vehicles (EVs) and hybrids. The timing is significant: India's electric vehicle market has crossed 198,000 units, registering 84% growth.

Experts say the group is likely to front-load investments to build a full-fledged ecosystem rather than scale gradually.

> JSW Green Mobility plans to launch its first passenger vehicle in FY27, but the CV timeline is yet to be finalized

"Investments in the automobile industry are inherently long term and increasingly ecosystem-driven. The companies that have struggled in India—and there have been many— tried to build the car business first and bolt on the ecosystem later. That approach doesn't work. You need products, manufacturing, localisation, batteries, charging, software, retail and service moving together from day one," Vinay Piparsania, founder at MillenStrat Advisory and Research said.

"Building an automotive brand no longer has to take 10–20 years— but only if capital, technology and ecosystem are committed together upfront, not sequenced. JSW has the financial depth, industrial capability and the execution bandwidth to compress that journey in a way most new entrants simply cannot. What makes their position particularly interesting is that they carry none of the legacy investment or ICE mindset that constrains every established player in this market."

To be sure, investments into JSW Green Mobility are separate from the conglomerate's investment in JSW MG Motor India which is a joint venture with China-based SAIC.

JSW's automobile business is housed under JSW Green Mobility that operates through two subsidiaries—JSW Motors (passenger vehicle business), and JSW Greentech (commercial vehicle business).

JSW Green Mobility is owned by Echelon Multiventures Pvt. Ltd, a Jindal family trust-backed firm. While JSW Motors is finalizing its lineup, JSW Greentech has secured approval from testing agency ARAI for its electric bus. Both firms have put in place leadership teams to drive strategy.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Dealers flag delays in automobile deliveries

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (Fada) on Monday flagged delays in vehicle deliveries from automakers across the commercial, passenger and two-wheeler segments—the first sign of supply disruption in India's auto industry due to the US-Iran war.

In its near-term outlook, the dealers' body said that over half of the auto dealers it surveyed reported supply-side challenges owing to the war, with the impact most evident on commercial vehicles.

"Our survey reveals that 53.2% of dealers have experienced some form of supply or dispatch disruption linked to the ongoing conflict, with 17.1% reporting significant delays of three or more weeks," Fada said.

And the impact on dealer inventories could worsen if the situation doesn't resolve in the next few weeks, warned C.S. Vigneshwar, president, Fada, in an interview with *Mint*. "Disruption means there's been a certain particular specification of vehicles the manufacturer is not able to give us."

Vigneswar, however, said consumer purchasing decisions remain unaffected, though dealers are urging customers to expedite purchases amid concerns over potential production disruptions.

"We've been telling customers, please come and pick up your vehicles, because there won't be a production issue. If there's a production issue, you won't be able to come and pick up the vehicles of your choice," Vigneshwar added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Why output hike by Opec+ won't cool oil prices

FROM FRONT FLAP

2 So, what did the Opec+ countries agree upon at their latest meeting?

The eight Opec+ countries—Saudi Arabia, Russia, Iraq, UAE, Kuwait, Kazakhstan, Algeria and Oman—on Sunday committed to back oil market stability and decided on a "production adjustment" of 206,000 bpd in May from the 1.65 million barrels of additional voluntary adjustment announced in April 2023. The grouping's joint ministerial monitoring committee also highlighted the importance of safeguarding international maritime routes to ensure uninterrupted flow of energy. It expressed concern regarding the recent attacks on energy infrastructure, and said that restoring damaged energy assets to full capacity was both costly and time-intensive, thereby affecting global supply of the crucial fuels.

AFP

3 Any other global steps to ease supply woes?

Last month, the IEA unanimously agreed to make 400 million barrels oil from their emergency reserves available to the market to address the supply disruptions. This is the largest ever release from reserves. This is the sixth time that the agency's members have taken emergency action to support oil markets in the history of the IEA, which was created in 1974. Previous collective actions were taken in 1991, 2005, 2011, and twice in 2022.

4 Will the latest move calm the oil market?

Unlikely. At the time of writing this piece, the Brent June contract on ICE traded at $108.60 a barrel, up 0.3% from its previous close. Experts say the output hike may not ease prices due to prospects of a prolonged war and the Strait of Hormuz blockade. Alternative fuel sources also won't be able to offset the 20% cut in supply from West Asia. Major consuming nations' panic has also made suppliers such as Russia and Iran sell their oil at a premium or lower discounts. And, *Reuters* said that Ukraine's attacks have hurt about 40% of Russia's oil export capacity, which may tighten global supplies even more.

5 How has India taken the oil price spurt?

The war-led market volatility has significantly hit India. Though crude oil, petrol and diesel supplies have been comfortable so far, retail prices of premium petrol and diesel and of industrial diesel have been hiked by state-run oil marketing firms. Private players Nayara and Shell have raised normal petrol and diesel price too. Government says the country has secured crude supply for two months' need. In a bid to avert price hikes in regular auto fuels, the Centre has slashed excise duty on them by ₹10 per litre, resulting in a gross fortnightly loss of about ₹7,000 crore to the exchequer.

Luxury hotels leveraging their brands in new vistas

Hotels eye branded residences and serviced apartments to diversify offerings

Varuni Khosla
varuni.k@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's luxury hotel chains such as Taj, Marriott, Leela, Oberoi, and Sarovar are exploring ways to capitalize on their brands by going beyond room bookings and into branded residences and serviced apartments to diversify their offerings.

The trend, which has been around for a few years, gathered pace in FY26, with at least half a dozen projects signed and launched across Mumbai, Gurugram, Noida, and Greater Noida as hospitality firms eyed more asset-light revenue streams tied to real estate.

Indian Hotels Co. Ltd, which runs the Taj brand of hotels, signed a pact to manage 74 Taj serviced apartments with the Gulshan Group in Noida last month. The Noida Expressway project will include a five-star hotel, with the developer investing ₹1,000 crore.

Indian Hotels already operates residences through Taj Wellington Mews, which has 80 fully furnished apartments in Colaba, Mumbai, and 112 apartments in Chennai.

Branded residences, on the other hand, are privately owned homes linked to a hotel brand, offering concierge and other services. There's a significant upside for hotel management firms that can earn an upfront fee for branding a residential development, in addition to recurring income from management and services in both these and serviced apartments.

"What's happening now is tokenization," said Ajay K. Bakaya, chairman of Sarovar Hotels and director of Louvre Hotels India. "In many of these, the hotel brand's name is used to sell the units, and that comes with an upfront fee, usually around 3–5% of the sale value, which is very significant. After that, if it's a serviced apartment format, the hotel can operate it much like a hotel apartment." He added that developers are increasingly selling individual units while using a hotel brand to market the project and, in some cases, operate it.

Branded residences are being sold as status products and investment assets.

Bakaya said such deals have picked up in the past two fiscal years. Sarovar itself has signed a project for 400 serviced apartments in Greater Noida and a similar 191-room one in Ghaziabad.

"These become a great extension of the hotel business. The marketing, operations and distribution are all familiar to hospitality companies and give hotels another way to earn beyond rooms and food and beverage," he said.

Roseate Hotels & Resorts entered into a partnership with developer M3M Group in February for branded residences at Trump Tower in Gurugram.

In July, Kalpataru and Ahluwalia Contracts tied up to build Westin Residences Gurugram, a 20-acre, ₹2,000-crore project. The Leela Palaces, Hotels & Resorts expects its luxury residences in Mumbai, to be ready by end 2026. Consultants said this is a win-win.

"For hotel companies, branded residences open up a new revenue stream beyond rooms. They earn through brand fees, commissions on sales and recurring service income, while staying asset-light," said Akash Datta, MD for South Asia at hospitality consultancy HVS ANAROCK. "Branded units can command 30-35% higher prices than non-branded homes (for developers). In many cases, what they make during the project's sales phase can rival lifetime earnings of a traditional hotel management contract."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

FOOT IN THE DOOR

THE trend gained pace in FY26 as firms eyed asset-light revenue streams tied to real estate

HOTEL companies are increasingly entering the segment largely held by non-hotel brands

DEVELOPERS are increasingly selling individual units while using a hotel brand to market projects

India is the fourth-largest refiner in the world. REUTERS

Refineries to put maintenance on hold amid Iran war

Rituraj Baruah
rituraj.baruah@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

State-run refineries will delay their maintenance schedules due to the ongoing war in West Asia and the resulting supply constraints, an official said on Monday.

To ensure a stable and continued supply of fuels, refineries of state-run Indian Oil Corp. Ltd (IOC) and Bharat Petroleum Corp. Ltd (BPCL) have postponed routine maintenance shutdowns at some of their refineries, Sujata Sharma, joint secretary at the ministry of petroleum and natural gas, told reporters on Monday.

Delaying refinery maintenance becomes critical as India needs a regular domestic supply of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), which is in short supply amid the war. Demand for petrol and diesel is also increasing at a record growth pace every year. India is the fourth-largest refiner in the world, with an annual crude processing capacity of 258 million tonnes.

However, the Vadinar refinery of Nayara Energy will move ahead with its 35-day maintenance starting this month, citing unavoidable circumstances and safety issues.

All refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, while sufficient stocks of petrol and diesel are being maintained, and the domestic LPG production from refineries has been increased to support domestic consumption, said Sharma.

LPG supply is affected by the prevailing geopolitical situation, but no dry-outs have been reported at LPG distributorships, she said. "Domestic LPG cylinder deliveries remain normal, with over 18 crore cylinders delivered to households since 1 March 2026."

She added that India's daily domestic LPG production declined to roughly 46,000-47,000 tonnes at present from around 50,000 tonnes in the last week of March 2026. "The decline is due to a change in refinery configuration due to a slight change in crude oil mix," she said, adding that there is a "sufficient" quantity to meet the demand.

Chip scarcity: Smartphone market leaders raise prices by up to 40%

FROM PAGE 1

mation. *Mint* has seen copies of the emails that retailers received announcing the price hikes. Vivo, Samsung and Oppo did not immediately respond to *Mint's* emailed queries seeking comment.

From 2 March to 16 March, Vivo India increased prices of two of its sub-₹20,000 smartphones—Vivo T4 Lite and T4x—by up to 17%. Vivo India, as per an internal pricing table of nine smartphones accessed by Mint via the All India Mobile Retailers Association (Aimra), increased prices over three tranches from 30 October to 16 March.

The cumulative hike is steep across devices. While Vivo's T4 Lite budget smartphone previously started at ₹9,999, it currently retails at ₹13,999—a 40% increase.

Samsung increased prices across its mid-range smartphones. The company's Galaxy A56 smartphone, which previously cost ₹47,999, currently retails at ₹62,499 in a marginally modified avatar under the 'A57' moniker—a price hike of 30%.

Its Galaxy A36 smartphone was launched under its new 'A37' avatar on 25 March at a price hike of 36%—up to ₹52,999 from ₹38,999 previously.

Oppo India has increased prices of five models by up to 18%—marking a flat hike of ₹2,000 on all phones ranging from ₹10,999 for Oppo A6x to ₹27,999 for A6 Pro.

Vivo, Samsung and Oppo accounted for 47% of the 152 million smartphones sold in the country last year, according to data from market researcher International Data Corp. (IDC) India. Taking Realme and Xiaomi into account, these five brands represent two-thirds of all smartphones sold in India every year—thus making the price hikes sweeping and significant.

The cumulative hike is steep across devices. MINT

Analysts and retailers said the price increases are very likely just the start.

According to Tarun Pathak, director for research at Counterpoint India, memory chip prices for smartphones have gone up by over 120% from December to February. This has led to significant disruption, which was absorbed over the past three months due to available inventory with retailers. Now, the impact is being felt—the cost of a memory chip is up to almost 40% of a smartphone's bill of materials cost from about 18% before, he said.

"Component makers are increasing prices to meet demand, and with consumer demand stagnant, brands are now passing the cost on to their retail networks," Pathak said.

Kailash Lakhyani, founding chairman of the All-India Mobile Retailers Association, added that retailers have already been told that the current price hikes are not only permanent, but further price increases will come through in the coming quarters.

"Most of the current price hikes are due to rising memory chip costs, while some of it is due to rising commodity costs such as plastic used for moulding in phones, due to the West Asia war. As per emails that we are receiving, brands have informed that there is no near-term respite, and further price hikes are likely as memory chip prices are unlikely to reduce before the first half of 2027," Lakhyani said.

The price hikes could lead to a 10% drop in smartphone sales annually, with a smartphone revenue crash

On Monday, Xiaomi started announcing price hikes. In an email to retailers, Xiaomi India's distribution network increased prices of its Redmi Pad tablet by 3-6% depending upon variants. Xiaomi told its retailers the price hike is permanent.

Through March, Xiaomi also increased prices of six of its smartphones by up to 32%. *Mint* has seen a copy of this email as well.

Realme too raised prices of nine of its models by up to 50%, including its sub-₹10,000 C71 4G.

Spokespersons for Xiaomi and Realme India did not immediately respond to *Mint's* queries.

The current price increases could lead to a drop of almost 10% in annual smartphone sales in India and a similar crash in net smartphone market revenue.

"The truth here is that smartphone makers are raising prices because component suppliers are catering to the high-demand AI memory chips," said Navkendar Singh, associate vice-president at IDC India. "This is unlikely to change in the near term."

Singh said the West Asia war has ensured that consumers are spending money only on necessary commodities as the cost of fuel and cooking gas shoot upward.

"Smartphones are thus emerging as an ancillary area of investment and even though phones are necessary today, new purchases are being held off," he said.

Singh added that even essential upgrades for smartphones are being held off.

"With prices rising steeply, buyers are looking at the second-hand market or are looking at temporary repairs to prolong their smartphone usage cycle—instead of buying new ones," he said.

RBI WALKS A FINE LINE ON RATES AND RUPEE

EXPERT VIEW

UPASNA BHARDWAJ

Respond to this column at **feedback@livemint.com**

As the monetary policy committee of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) meets for its decision on 8 April, geopolitics has moved from being a peripheral risk to being the centre of the macro landscape. The West Asia conflict has disrupted energy and logistics flows, with spillovers via oil, gas, fertilizers, freight, insurance and even remittances as traffic around the Strait of Hormuz remains constrained. In such unsettling times, the traditional baselines have become blurry, with RBI's predominant task shifting more towards safeguarding macro and financial stability as tail risks increase.

Severe trade disruptions through the strait have triggered broad spillovers across energy and related commodities. Although the direct supply shock disproportionately hits heavy energy-importing Asian economies such as Korea, Japan, China, Thailand, Philippines and India, the larger concern is the second-order inflation impulse now threatening to disrupt global monetary policy trajectories.

Domestically, the Indian economy entered the crisis with resilient activity indicators and still-supportive demand. Further, the inflation environment too has remained benign. February retail and wholesale inflation was 3.2% and 2.1%, respectively.

However, persistent supply shocks are skewing the inflation distribution sharply higher, despite the government and oil marketing companies cushioning the impact for now. We expect the pass-through to consumers to begin in a month or two. Furthermore, inflation risks are increasing amid a weakening rupee, rising probability of sub-par monsoons, and risks of fertilizer shortage. On the positive side, heavy buffer food stocks should help cap some of the monsoon-led risks to food inflation.

While we do see risk of gross domestic product (GDP) growth falling towards 6.5% (from 7% pre-crisis period) and average inflation rising to 4.7% (from 4.1% earlier) with further upside risk in FY27, we remain more wary on the increasing vulnerability to the external balance. Even before the recent crisis, the current account deficit (CAD) was being weighed down by higher goods trade deficit with services exports and remittances offering significant offsets.

In the current scenario, the import bill is expected to surge significantly not just from oil imports, but also gas, fertilizer and other inputs. Exports too will be impacted, especially to West Asia, worsening the CAD—we expect CAD/GDP at 2.2% compared to ~1% estimated prior to the crisis. Compounding this impact is the unrelenting capital outflows—foreign portfolio investors outflows in March surged to $15.5 billion following a brief inflow of $3.5 billion in February. If such risk-off sentiments continue, the balance of payments (BoP) deficit is estimated to widen towards $75 billion, in the absence of RBI special measures.

The rupee has already been acting as a shock absorber, depreciating by about 11% in FY26 and 4.2% against the US dollar in March amid a sharp rise in crude oil prices, supply disruptions and risk-off driven capital outflows reflecting uncertainty over the duration of the conflict. While currency depreciation is necessary to correct emerging external sector imbalances, excessively sharp moves risk triggering a self-reinforcing downward spiral. Beyond eroding confidence, a weaker rupee accentuates imported inflation, hardens inflation expectations, and complicates RBI's inflation-control mandate.

While RBI has been defending the fall in the rupee, its ability to do so is increasingly getting constrained by declining foreign currency assets, valuation-loss risks to forex reserves, and a sizeable short-forward book. It is in this context, the central bank has already started taking aggressive measures like curbing speculative activity against the rupee through recent actions like capping the banks daily onshore currency open positions to $100 million, followed by prohibiting banks to offer non-deliverable derivative contracts to resident/non-resident users along with restricting rebooking any forex derivative contract involving the rupee.

Geopolitics has moved from a peripheral risk to the centre of the macro landscape

Given that the fundamentals don't remain supportive of the rupee in the near term, the persistence of the crisis will necessitate RBI to revisit elements of its 2013 toolkit—compressing dollar demand through tighter rules on its Liberalised Remittance Scheme for investments abroad, overseas direct investments and gold imports; exploring a dedicated dollar window for oil importers; and easing select norms to help banks mobilize foreign capital.

While memories of RBI's surprise 200 basis points marginal standing facility (MSF) hike in 2013 to arrest rupee depreciation remain fresh, we believe the central bank should, for now, exhaust alternative tools to contain forex volatility and ease BoP pressures before resorting to rate hikes purely to defend the rupee. In case of a supply shock, rate hike tends to be a blunt tool. (MSF allows banks to borrow emergency overnight money when interbank lending markets are relatively illiquid.)

April's policy, therefore, is more about how RBI communicates on liquidity, growth-inflation scenarios, forex volatility management and other prudential/control measures rather than the repo rate/liquidity adjustment facility (LAF) corridor itself. (LAF is another RBI tool to manage short-term liquidity in the banking system.)

Status quo on rates and policy stance is the cleanest decision, with a more hawkish reaction contingent on data. RBI should highlight the upside risk to inflation from energy, currency weakness, and weaker monsoons.

For now, we expect RBI to focus more towards safeguarding macro/financial stability through adequate guidance. If the global risk-off continues to weigh on the rupee, the central bank will soon need to resort to tightening liquidity conditions (via variable reverse repo rate, cash management bill issuances, open market operation sales) to anchor the overnight rates towards MSF. Notably, the recent measures on the Indian rupee is expected to keep it supported in the near term, which in turn is expected to provide an opportune window for RBI to mop up forex reserves and cap the appreciation. The liquidity conditions are already comfortable and hence there will be a need to introduce liquidity-tightening measures to avoid additional easing and ensure overnight hover between repo and MSF rate. This could be followed by a repo rate hike if market stress continues to intensify. Either way, monetary policy must stay steady, nimble and operationally proactive.

Upasna Bhardwaj is chief economist at Kotak Mahindra Bank. Views are personal.

LPG crisis triggers labour crunch; hiring cost up 15%

Workers retreat as the ongoing war triggers LPG supply crunch, spiking the cost of living

Sowmya Ramasubramanian,
Madhurima Nandy & Devina Sengupta

BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Staffing firms have reported a 10-15% rise in hiring costs over a month, while hiring agents closely track labour demand trends in the consumer, banking, and construction industries.

"We do blue-collar hiring, mainly in the manufacturing and supply chain sectors, and there, the costs of getting workforce in the metros has gone up by about 15–20% in a month," said Neeti Sharma, chief executive officer of TeamLease Digital, part of the staffing firm TeamLease Group.

Scarcity of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) has forced blue-collar workers—scaffolders, plumbers, welders, etc.—engaged by the construction and manufacturing sectors back to their home towns and villages.

Radheshyam and four others together iron clothes in south Mumbai. These migrant workers from Rae Bareli, Uttar Pradesh, together typically use one LPG cylinder for a little over a month. "A cylinder costs us ₹1,000, but yesterday I bought it for ₹5,000," he said. "Many of my neighbours, who work as labourers, have returned to their villages. We have managed to get the cylinder this time. But going ahead, we don't know..."

Upcoming assembly polls in four states—Assam, Kerala, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu—is yet another push factor for many from these states to be home, hiring firms said.

Ironically, this tightness in labour supply comes even as many blue-collar workers' plans to work in West Asia—the Gulf Cooperation Council, UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar and Saudi Arabia—are disrupted by the war.

Sachin Chhabra, founder and chief executive at Nia.one, a platform that provides living facilities, food and other essential support services for migrant workers, said they are indeed returning to their home towns.

"Workers have been complaining and struggling to meet food costs. We have workers who have started availing the food service we offer, instead of cooking themselves or arranging it from elsewhere, because of the LPG shortage and costs," Chhabra said. Nia.one, which offers a meal for ₹49, has around 8,000 workers enlisted and it operates in the manufacturing hubs of Pune in Maharashtra, Sriperumbudur and Hosur in Tamil Nadu, and Farrukhnagar near Gurugram in Haryana.

Mint had Monday reported developers in Mumbai, Delhi-NCR and Pune said the gas price spike had led to a dip in labour supply in key markets.

"There is a visible but controlled increase in labour costs, typically in the range of 5–10% across certain categories and geographies. But the more important point is why. This is not just wage inflation—it is cost-of-survival inflation. When everyday essentials become expensive, labour does not negotiate; it reprices," said Ashwinder R. Singh, chairman of the Confederation of Indian Industry Real Estate Committee. "Labour costs have already risen 5–15% due to the demand-supply mismatch, developers estimated, with the long-term impact likely to be more severe".

Staffing firm Adecco is taking fortnightly reviews, instead of the usual monthly ones, to understand changes in demand. "After the war started, there is a tightness in demand in medium and small-scale enterprises, FMCG and the textile industry," said Sunil C, country manager for Adecco India. Manufacturing and banking, financial services and insurance are still hiring "as of now".

For temporary and blue collared hiring, April-November is crucial as sales shoot up during the summer, holiday and festive seasons.

"We're looking at a muted hiring period if the war continues for a few more weeks, and there will be concerns from the demand side," noted Sunil C.

Some attribute the issue to seasonal factors too. A big part of the migrant workforce went home for Holi and did not return, leading to a 20% drop in headcount at its peak, said Ajay Rao, founder and CEO of logistics firm Emiza. "This was compounded by issues such as LPG cylinder shortages that impacted plans to return."

Some firms are taking a calibrated view to manage costs and double down on retention. Angad Singh, founding team member at quick commerce enablement platform Zippee, indicated firms are investing more in staff welfare and efficiency, while also raising incentives. This includes hikes in performance and tenure linked payouts.

sowmya.r@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.


Scarcity of cooking gas has forced blue-collar workers engaged by construction and manufacturing sectors back to their home towns and villages.. AFP

HOMEWARD BOUND

UPCOMING polls in Assam, Kerala, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu was another push factor for workers

THE labour supply crunch comes even as West Asia war disrupts workers' emigration plans

FMCG and textile markets may see muted hiring as the war in West Asia rages on

SOME industry players are attributing the workforce crunch to seasonal factors

IPL advertisement mix gets a healthy makeover this season

Neethi Lisa Rojan
neethi.rojan@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Indian Premier League's (IPL's) advertising mix is undergoing a shift, with pharmaceutical and wellness brands entering a play dominated by impulse-driven products such as soft drinks and mouth fresheners.

Data from TAM Sports, based on the first four matches of this season, shows healthcare as a standout new category, even as most additions are extensions of existing electronics and FMCG segments.

The shift signals a broader repositioning of IPL advertising, from indulgence-led consumption to health-conscious messaging, as brands work on changing buyer preferences and look to embed wellness into mass-market narratives.

The IPL advertising pool, pegged at ₹4,900–5,200 crore, has traditionally been dominated by FMCG and consumer electronics players.

"IPL has always reflected where India's aspirations are headed. And today, India wants to be healthier, not just entertained," said Ripal Chopda, chief marketing officer at The Sleep Company, whose campaign has M.S. Dhoni linking sleep to overall health.

The shift is playing out beyond traditional advertising slots and into team-level partnerships and product integrations. Sun Pharmaceutical Industries has signed a three-year principal sponsorship and health partnership with Royal Challengers Bengaluru—the first such direct association between a major drugmaker and an IPL franchise. While the exact figure is not public, the deal is pegged at ₹70-100 crore per year.

Healthcare advertising in India is tightly regulated. The Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, bars advertising of prescription drugs, limiting the firms to over-the-counter products such as multivitamins and pain relief brands such as Revital and Volini.

Within those constraints, brands are aligning health messaging with the IPL's performance-driven context. Colgate-Palmolive India Ltd, for instance, has partnered with Mumbai Indians as its 'Dental Performance Partner', launching an oral health screening initiative that links dental metrics to athletic performance. The campaign draws on FC Barcelona's La Liga 2024 season title-winning effort that brought dental tests into pre-season medical checks.

"The science has always existed but the ways to engage with consumers have increased," said Gunjit Jain, executive vice-president of marketing at Colgate-Palmolive India.

Supplement brands are also leaning into team affiliations and co-branded products. Pure Nutrition has tied up with Chennai Super Kings as its official sports nutrition partner, launching a range of co-branded whey protein, creatine monohydrate, lean meal shakes, pre-workout supplements, and mass gainers. It is also bundling official CSK merchandise with purchases.

"We track key indicators across the IPL window including website traffic, sales velocity, new customer acquisition, category mix, and repeat purchase behaviour," said Sushil Khaitan, founder and managing director of Pure Nutrition.

Beyond formal partnerships, the wider advertising ecosystem is adopting the playbook. Packaged food and beverage makers are positioning products as "healthy" or "guilt-free", aligning with match-day consumption. Brands are bundling nuts, protein bars and functional beverages into IPL-themed offerings, reframing indulgence as mindful consumption.

The pivot is unfolding on one of India's largest advertising stages. IPL 2026 has reached over 515 million viewers across platforms, per Jiostar, after drawing a record 1.19 billion viewers last year.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

IPL's advertising pool had so far been dominated by FMCG and consumer electronics players


Sun Pharma has signed a three-year principal sponsorship and health partnership with Royal Challengers Bengaluru. PTI

Jamie Dimon warns of higher inflation, interest rates from Iran war

Alexander Saeedy
feedback@livemint.com

JPMorgan Chase Chief Executive Jamie Dimon warned that the war in Iran could push up inflation and drag down financial markets even further if interest rates start to rise.

In his annual letter to shareholders, Dimon said there is a risk of more oil and commodity price shocks in the months ahead, which could lead to prolonged inflation and ultimately higher interest rates.

"The skunk at the party—and it could happen in 2026—would be inflation slowly going up," Dimon wrote. "This alone could cause interest rates to rise and asset prices to drop."

The 70-year-old CEO also noted how rapid increases in oil prices helped cause large recessions in the 1970s and 1980s, though the U.S. is less vulnerable to those types of shocks today.

Dimon also said the outcome of conflicts between the world's great powers, including the wars in Ukraine and Iran, is more important than the financial or economic impacts they might bring.

"We should not turn a blind eye to the role the current regime in Iran has played in fostering terrorism and killing thousands of people, including Americans and many of its own citizens, over many years," Dimon said. "That threat must be addressed in an appropriate manner."

Dimon's annual letter to shareholders has become a tradition since he became chief executive in the 2000s. Over the years, he has moved beyond focusing on JPMorgan's performance to sharing broader geopolitical and socioeconomic commentary, often warning of what he sees as underappreciated risks to the economy and world.

He offered advice on how the European Union should reform, gave suggestions on how to improve the U.S. public education system and claimed that higher taxes had caused an exodus of people from cities like New York. He said that while the city remains JPMorgan's headquarters, the bank has shrunk its head count there and warned that no city had a "divine right to success."

There was plenty about Wall Street in this year's letter, too. JPMorgan is right in the middle of the ongoing reckoning in private credit, and Dimon predicted that most types of high-risk credit would take a bigger-than-expected hit in a downturn as underwriting standards among many lenders have deteriorated.

He also argued that the push from private credit funds to sell investments to retail clients required "greater transparency" and "higher standards" than was currently the case.

"Not everyone providing credit is necessarily good at it," Dimon said. "There are many players who are late to this game, and it should be expected that some credit providers will do a far worse job than others."

He also took a jab at the private equity industry, which has been the subject of criticism in past missives to his shareholders.

"With stock markets at all-time highs in recent months, it is a little surprising that private equity firms, which own close to 13,000 companies, have not taken greater advantage of healthy markets to take their companies public," he said. "It's hard to imagine what will happen if and when we have an extended bear market."

Left unmentioned in this year's letter was a recent lawsuit brought by President Trump against JPMorgan and Dimon for closing his bank accounts after the Jan. 6, 2021, riot at the U.S. Capitol. Dimon said he supported the deregulatory push Trump has fostered since he took office, adding that JPMorgan planned to help the White House achieve its broader policy goals by supporting industries critical to the country's military and economic security.

"JPMorganChase is well-positioned to do its part," Dimon said.


JPMorgan Chase Chief Executive Jamie Dimon. REUTERS

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Israeli airstrike kills at least 10 people near Gaza school

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
CAIRO/GAZA

An Israeli airstrike killed at least 10 people and wounded several others outside a school housing displaced Palestinians on Monday, health officials said, in the latest violence overshadowing the fragile US-backed Gaza ceasefire deal.

Before the strikes, some Palestinians had clashed with members of an Israeli-backed militia, who they said attacked the school in an attempt to abduct some people, medics and residents said.

In the midst of the clashes, east of the Maghazi refugee camp in the central Gaza Strip, Israeli drones fired two missiles into the area, killing at least 10 people and wounding several others, they added.

It was not immediately clear how many civilians had been killed in the strikes, which hit in a closely packed neighbourhood of mostly displaced Palestinians.

Ahmed al-Maghazi, an eyewitness, said their area was attacked by members of the Israeli-backed militia who operate in the territory adjacent to where the Israeli forces are in control, before the militia opened fire.

Later on Monday, a leader of one of the Israeli-backed militias said in a video, which *Reuters* couldn't immediately authenticate, that they killed some five Hamas members.

Iran rejects ceasefire as Trump amps up threats

Iran's rejection came after Israel hit a key petchem plant, killed two paramilitary commanders

AP
feedback@livemint.com
TEHRAN, IRAN


Trump stepped up his threats against Iran, telling a press conference: "The entire country can be taken out in one night..." AFP

Iran on Monday rejected a 45-day ceasefire proposal and said it wants a permanent end to the war, even as Israel attacked a major gas field and US President Donald Trump's Tuesday ultimatum to open the Strait of Hormuz loomed.

"We only accept an end of the war with guarantees that we won't be attacked again," Mojtaba Ferdousi Pour, head of Iran's diplomatic mission in Cairo, told *The Associated Press*. He said Iran no longer trusts the Trump administration after the US bombed the Islamic Republic twice during previous rounds of talks.

Iran's state-run *IRNA* news agency said Tehran conveyed its response through Pakistan, a key mediator.

And yet a regional official involved in talks said efforts had not collapsed. "We are still talking to both sides," he said, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss closed-door diplomacy.

Trump later stepped up his threats against Iran, telling a press conference: "The entire country can be taken out in one night, and that night might be tomorrow night."

Iranian and Omani officials were working on a mechanism for administrating the strait, through which a fifth of the world's oil is shipped in peacetime. Iran's grip on it has shaken the world economy. Tehran has refused to let US and Israeli vessels through after they started the war on 28 February.

Iran's rejection came after Israel struck a key petrochemical plant in the South Pars natural gas field and killed two paramilitary Revolutionary Guard commanders.

The gas field attack aimed at eliminating a major source of revenue for Iran, Israel said. The field, the world's largest, is shared with Qatar. It is critical to electricity production, but the strike appeared to be separate from Trump's threats.

An earlier Israeli attack on the field in March prompted Iran to target energy infrastructure in other Middle East countries, a major escalation.

Trump has warned Iran that the US could set the country "back to the stone ages."

Word of Iran's rejection came while Trump addressed an Easter event on the White House lawn, and it was not clear whether he was aware.

He threatened to go further on Iran. "If I had my choice, what would I like to do? Take the oil," he said, suggesting it could be done easily, but "unfortunately the American people would like to see us come home."

Asked if Tuesday at 8pm Washington time was his final deadline, Trump replied simply, "Yeah."

Egyptian, Pakistani and Turkish mediators had sent Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi and US Mideast envoy Steve Witkoff a proposal calling for a 45-day ceasefire and the strait's reopening, two Mideast officials told the *AP*. The officials spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the private negotiations.

Iran's foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei earlier told journalists that "negotiations are entirely incompatible with ultimatums, crimes and threats of war crimes."

> **Iranian and Omani officials were working on a mechanism for administrating the Strait of Hormuz**

Former Iranian foreign minister Ali Akbar Velayatir urged Arab countries to discourage Trump from striking power plants, warning the entire region would go "dark" if that happens.

Brent crude oil, the international standard, rose to $109 in early Monday spot trading, about 50% higher than when the war started, then wavered. US stocks mostly held steady.

Explosions boomed in Tehran, and low-flying jets could be heard for hours.

The head of intelligence for Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, Maj. Gen. Majid Khademi, was killed, according to Iranian state media and Israel's defence minister. Israel said it also killed the leader of the Revolutionary Guard's undercover unit in its expeditionary Quds Force, Asghar Bakeri.

"We will continue to hunt them down one by one," Israeli defence minister Israel Katz said of top officials.

Israel's military later said it struck three Tehran airports overnight—Bahram, Mehrabad and Azmayesh—hitting dozens of helicopters and aircraft it said belonged to the Iranian Air Force.

A Tehran resident said "constantly there is the sound of bombs, air defences, drones," speaking on condition of anonymity for her safety. Another resident said he takes sleeping pills to get through nightly bombardments, and said people worry about power, gas and water cuts. "Stop this war," he said.

Separately, Kuwait, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia activated air defences to intercept Iranian missiles and drones. Tehran has kept up pressure on Gulf neighbours, including strikes against infrastructure like oil fields.

In Israel, Iranian missiles hit the northern city of Haifa, where four people from one family were found dead in the rubble of a residential building.

Smoke rose near Tehran's Azadi Square after an airstrike hit the grounds of the Sharif University of Technology. Multiple countries have sanctioned the university for its work with the military, particularly on Iran's ballistic missile program.

Iranian media reported damage to buildings and a nearby natural gas distribution site. The university is empty as the war forced schools into online classes.

A strike near Eslamshar, south-west of Tehran, killed at least 15 people, authorities said. Five were killed in a residential area in Qom, and six were killed in strikes on other cities, the state-run *IRAN* daily newspaper reported. Three people were killed at a home in Tehran, state television reported.

In Lebanon, where Israel has launched air attacks and a ground invasion that it says target the Iran-linked Hezbollah militia, an airstrike hit an apartment in Ain Saadeh, a predominantly Christian town east of Beirut. It killed an official in the Lebanese Forces, a Christian political party strongly opposed to Hezbollah, his wife and another woman.

"We had always felt safe here," family friend Nadine Naameh said.

More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran since the war began, but the government has not updated the toll for days.

More than 1,400 people have been killed in Lebanon and more than 1 million people have been displaced. Eleven Israeli soldiers have died there.

In Gulf Arab states and the occupied West Bank, more than two dozen people have died, while 23 have been reported dead in Israel and 13 US service members have been killed.

A downed airman, a mountain hideout and a high-risk rescue in Iran

Vera Bergengruen, Alexander Ward, Michael R. Gordon & Shelby Holliday

For nearly two days, injured and alone, a U.S. aviator hid in a remote mountain crevice as Iranian forces and militias closed in on him with helicopters and drones.

"God is good," the Air Force colonel had radioed once he reached an elevated ridge, a message that was initially met with suspicion in Washington as a possible Iranian trap as officials scrambled to verify he was still alive.

Early Sunday, he heard the heavier roar of U.S. aircraft and a barrage of fire as U.S. commandos reached him 200 miles deep inside Iran. As they whisked him to safety, they blew up aircraft stranded on the ground rather than risk the sophisticated military equipment falling into Iranian hands, leaving behind a final explosion and a plume of smoke.

The rescue mission that U.S. officials said unfolded in the craggy gorges of southwestern Iran was the kind of operation that military commanders both plan for and dread: a downed American airman in enemy territory, hostile forces converging and early attempts faltering under fire.

The aviator, who hasn't been identified, had been one of the two crew flying in an F-15E Strike Eagle with the aircraft call sign "Dude 44" when it was shot down by Iranian forces on Friday.

Shortly after the plane crashed, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, briefed President Trump about the situation, according to U.S. officials. They told him the Pentagon had long planned for this scenario and could rescue the airman.

Once the Pentagon confirmed the aviator's identity, Hegseth rushed to the Oval Office to tell him and seek a final order, officials said. Trump immediately gave his approval: "We have to get him," Trump said, according to White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The effort to recover the officer set off a sprawling, high-risk rescue mission involving some 100 special-operations forces, dozens of U.S. warplanes and helicopters, and a last-minute Central Intelligence Agency deception campaign to buy more time, the officials said.

"When airmen go down, you can't get them in very tough countries, like in Vietnam," Trump told *The Wall Street Journal* on Sunday morning. "He was able to climb, though he was as wounded as he was, he was able to climb up into a crevice," the president continued, saying the airman could hear the U.S. forces looking for him. "A lot of great things happened."

Troops led by Central Command brought a devastating array of firepower to keep its enemy at bay. Four B-1 bombers, part of a larger air armada, dropped nearly 100 2,000-pound satellite-guided bombs, according to two U.S. officials. MQ-9 Reaper drones also struck suspected fighters as they approached within kilometers of the aviator's hiding site.

The search for an American airman stranded behind enemy lines jolted the U.S., making what had been an abstract air war feel visceral beyond the grainy footage of explosions released by the White House.

It also provided both sides with a new narrative as the war enters its sixth week. The Iranian regime has portrayed the downing of the jet as proof that the U.S. could be bloodied and has challenged Trump's claims of American air superiority.

In triumphant interviews and posts, Trump and some of his allies have been calling the successful operation an "Easter miracle" as the administration seeks to mobilize flagging public support for the war.

"Open the Fuckin' Strait, you crazy bastards, or you'll be living in Hell," Trump posted on Truth Social early Easter morning about the Strait of Hormuz, the strategic waterway that Iran has largely closed to commercial traffic since the war began. In a separate post, the president gave Iran an 8 p.m. Tuesday deadline to comply before the U.S. starts targeting bridges and electric plants.


The U.S. mounted a high-stakes mission to rescue the injured airman. REUTERS

The most famous rescue operation that the U.S. has previously attempted in Iran—aimed at freeing 53 U.S. Embassy staff hostages nearly 46 years ago—had failed dramatically after a series of mishaps, punctuated by a fiery crash at a desert staging area.

Worst-case scenario

When the F-15E came under fire on Friday, the aircrew pulled their ejection handle, which blew the canopy, blasted the seats out of the cockpit and deployed their parachutes. Below them, the damaged plane crashed hundreds of miles inside Iranian territory.

But while a U.S. military team was able to quickly rescue the pilot, the other crew member who flew in the back seat of the fighter as a weapons-systems officer went missing.

"We didn't play up the first one, because then they would have found out about the second one. So by not talking about the first one, it took them a day and a half to find out there was a second one," Trump told the Journal on Sunday about the missing airman.

The news first broke on Iranian state television. Reading from a sheet of paper, a female anchor announced that a U.S. aircrew had ejected from a plane in southwestern Iran. The Americans were believed to be in Kohgiluyeh and Boyer-Ahmad, a mountainous province of steep ridgelines.

She urged "all tribespeople and villagers" to cooperate with the military and law enforcement. "If you capture the enemy pilot or pilots alive and hand them over to the police, you will receive a precious prize," she said, with a backdrop of a military march.

For the Pentagon, this was a worst-case scenario. It was the first time a piloted U.S. aircraft had been lost over enemy territory in more than 20 years, military experts said. Video footage of a captured U.S. airman in enemy hands would have handed Tehran a major propaganda tool and a source of leverage at a critical moment in the war. U.S. officials worried that the regime would use the airman's capture to seek maximalist concessions.

Trump was in the Oval Office on Friday and Saturday to receive constant updates from Hegseth, Leavitt said. Hegseth repeatedly visited the White House to deliver in-person briefings.

Soon after the airman landed, he was able to get to an elevated ridge and make contact by activating an emergency beacon to send his proof of life, according to senior officials. But as he went deeper into hiding in the mountainous terrain, communication went in and out as U.S. officials sought to keep track of his location.

The complex mission quickly ran into problems, officials said .

As the U.S. redirected aircraft in the region to help with the mission, some planned targets—including missile launcher sites—were left untouched. That allowed Iran to fire more weapons than usual in recent days, officials said.

The first attempt to rescue the airman had to be aborted. Two H-6 helicopters took small-arms fire from the ground, wounding the crews in both aircraft and requiring them to land safely in Kuwait, officials said.

When two MC-130Js, a special-operations aircraft, landed in a makeshift forward-operating base inside Iran they ran into problems when their nose wheels sank into the ground and couldn't take off, officials said. There was a contingency plan: Three smaller planes carrying specialized teams later made their way to the remote staging area.

Time was of the essence. Regular Iranian forces, pro-regime militia and members of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps were on the airman's trail, using helicopters and drones to find him. The U.S. deployed MQ-9 Reaper drones and other aircraft to strike the Iranian trackers, giving the airman a greater chance of survival.

The CIA also helped with the operation. After using its capabilities to pinpoint the aviator's location to a mountain crevice, which a senior administration official described as finding a needle in a haystack, the agency shared that information with the Pentagon and White House, and continued to feed real-time information over the course of the operation.

The CIA also carried out a deception operation to throw the Iranians off the airman's track. As the aviator hid from Iranian forces, the agency spread false word inside the country that the U.S. military had already located the downed airman and were preparing to move him overland for exfiltration.

Other U.S. intelligence agencies also provided support to the mission, officials said. U.S. officials coordinated with Israel to share intelligence and pause attacks in the area to help the mission, a U.S. and Israeli official said.

Israel also conducted strikes in the operation area in coordination with U.S. forces, striking assets that could pose a threat to the evacuation effort, the Israeli official said.

Once the mission was complete, the U.S. destroyed the two stuck MC-130Js, which cost more than $100 million each, and two MH-6 Little Bird helicopters, so that their sensitive technology wouldn't be compromised after they were left behind.

After hours of speculation, Trump posted the news shortly after midnight: "WE GOT HIM!" Trump wrote on Truth Social. "The U.S. Military sent dozens of aircraft, armed with the most lethal weapons in the World, to retrieve him. He sustained injuries, but he will be just fine."

feedback@livemint.com

NEWS IN NUMBERS

$375 mn

THE AMOUNT Wipro will pay to acquire Mindsprint, Olam Group's IT arm, as part of a broader $1 billion, eight-year contract with the food processing giant

19-20%

THE ON-YEAR gross order value growth Elara Capital has projected for Swiggy and Eternal in Q4FY26, driven by a shift in demand to QSRs, non-LPG venues

5,443

THE NUMBER of shows of *Dhurandhar 2*, which has grossed ₹1,215.83 crore at the domestic box office in the 19 days since its release, currently running across India

200

THE NUMBER of roles Meta is eliminating at its Silicon Valley office, as CEO Mark Zuckerberg accelerates the company's AI push and streamlines its workforce

202

THE NUMBER of wickets claimed by Bhuvneshwar Kumar from 192 Indian Premier League matches, the first fast bowler to reach the milestone

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Rupee records biggest surge in 12 years

The rupee closed 0.1% higher at 93.0612 per dollar after rising as much as 0.4% on Monday. REUTERS

The Indian rupee edged up, extending its biggest rally in 12 years after the central bank doubled down on curbing speculation against the local currency.

The rupee closed 0.1% higher at 93.0612 per dollar after rising as much as 0.4% on Monday. The currency gave up some gains on dollar purchases by local importers and oil refiners, according to Anil Kumar Bhansali, head of treasury at Finrex Treasury Advisors.

The currency rallied 1.8% on Thursday, the most since September 2013. It may gain further toward the 91.50-92 range as banks unwind their dollar positions ahead of the 10 April deadline, according to Amit Pabari, managing director at CR Forex. Local markets were shut for the Good Friday holiday. The rupee swung sharply in a holiday-shortened week after the Reserve Bank of India unleashed measures to restrict banks in the onshore forward market.

The rupee had been hitting successive lows despite repeated intervention by RBI, with pressure intensifying after the Iran war drove up India's fuel import costs. The unit has tumbled 8.2% over the past year, making it Asia's worst-performing currency. BLOOMBERG

REUTERS

Wilson resigns as Air India CEO, on notice period

The tenure of Campbell Wilson, hired from Scoot in May 2022, was to end in July 2027

Dipali Banka
dipali.banka@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Air India chief executive Campbell Wilson has stepped down from the helm of India's second-largest airline, and is currently serving his notice period, two people with direct knowledge of the matter said.

Mint independently could not ascertain when Wilson's notice ends, or whether the Tata Group has found a successor to steer the airline. An email sent to Air India seeking comment went unanswered.

The Tata Group had hired Wilson from Singapore Airlines' low-cost unit Scoot in May 2022, less than four months after the conglomerate acquired the government-run airline for ₹18,000 crore. His tenure was to end in July 2027.

Following the acquisition, the Tata Group merged Vistara, a 51:49 joint venture between Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines Ltd, with Air India. Consequently, Singapore Airlines became a 25.1% shareholder in Air India, while Tata Sons owns 74.9%.

However, in Wilson's third year at the airline, things took a turn for the worse on 12 June, when an Air India flight from Ahmedabad to London crashed shortly after takeoff. This led to increased scrutiny, inspections and a temporary grounding of several aircraft, straining operations.

Subsequently, India-Pakistan conflict led to the closure of Pakistan's airspace, hurting Indian airlines' international flights. The war in West Asia compounded challenges, driving up fuel costs, extending flight durations, and limiting viable routes.

Four years into its turnaround under the Tata fold, Air India's $400 million aircraft retrofit programme is two years behind schedule, Wilson told Mint earlier. The delay has slowed fleet upgrades and international expansion, though the airline says costs remain on track and most designs are finalized.

In FY25, Air India's standalone revenue rose 13% to ₹61,080 crore. Under Wilson, it cut losses to ₹3,976 crore from ₹5,031 crore a year earlier. Air India's standalone borrowings (excluding lease liabilities) stood at ₹29,713 crore, down over 8% from ₹32,465 crore in FY24.

Indian firms' NDF trading surges 7x

Indian companies' activity in the non-deliverable forwards (NDF) market surged to over $7 billion on 30 March, around seven times the average, signalling a rush to capture arbitrage opportunities created by banks unwinding positions following regulatory curbs. The unwinding followed the Reserve Bank of India's imposition of restrictions on lenders' net onshore open FX positions, prompting a rush to lower positions aimed at benefiting from gaps between onshore and non-deliverable forwards.

With banks selling dollars in the domestic market and simultaneously buying them in NDF to close the trades, the spread between the two widened, creating arbitrage opportunities that corporates exploited by buying dollars onshore and selling in NDF.

Client trading volumes in the NDF market jumped manifold to $7.54 billion on 30 March, Clearing Corp. of India data showed. PTI

Indices rebound as crude oil softens

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty staged a sharp rebound on Monday after falling in early trade following a correction in crude oil prices amid reports of ceasefire efforts in the West Asia war.

Intense buying in banking and IT stocks, and a strengthening rupee, supported investor sentiment, traders said.

In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 787.30 points, or 1.07%, to settle at 74,106.85. During the day, it surged 887.91 points, or 1.21%, to 74,207.46.

A total of 3,207 stocks advanced, while 1,147 declined and 190 remained unchanged on the BSE. The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 255.15 points, or 1.12 %, to end at 22,968.25. PTI

India adds record wind capacity

India has achieved the highest-ever annual wind energy capacity addition of 6.05GW in 2025-26, taking cumulative installed capacity to over 56GW, the ministry of new and renewable energy said on Monday. According to a ministry statement, India achieved its highest-ever annual wind capacity addition of 6.05GW during 2025-26, crossing the landmark of 5.5GW capacity addition in 2016-17. With this addition, India's cumulative installed wind power capacity has crossed 56GW, the ministry said.

This milestone reflects renewed momentum in the sector, driven by improved policy clarity, transmission readiness, competitive tariff discovery, and a strong project pipeline. PTI

Gold of 99.9% purity advanced by ₹2,300, or 1.52%, to ₹1,53,800 per 10 grams. AFP

Silver up ₹5,000, gold ₹2,300 as dollar dips

Silver prices jumped ₹5,000 to ₹2.42 lakh per kilogramme in the national capital on Monday, while gold advanced to ₹1.53 lakh per 10 grams due to easing crude oil rates and a weak US dollar. According to the All India Sarafa Association, the white metal appreciated by ₹5,000, or 2.11%, to ₹2,42,000 per kg (inclusive of all taxes) from Friday's closing level of ₹2,37,000 per kg. Gold of 99.9 per cent purity also advanced by ₹2,300, or 1.52%, to ₹1,53,800 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes). It had settled at ₹1,51,500 per 10 grams in the previous session.

Analysts said bullion prices recovered amid value buying following the recent decline in precious metals.

Gold prices recovered on Monday as traders engaged in bargain buying, supported by a pullback in the US dollar and a decrease in oil prices, Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

He added that precious metals are expected to remain sensitive to incoming geopolitical developments in West Asia, which will continue to play a crucial role in shaping market direction in the domestic markets. PTI

Godrej Consumer expects to offset the impact of cost increases through price hikes. MINT

GCPL sees hit if oil prices remain high

Godrej Consumer Products Ltd (GCPL) said on Monday it expects costs to rise 6% to 9% if Brent crude holds at $100 to $110 a barrel and palm oil prices hover between 4,500 and 4,800 Malaysian ringgit a metric tonne. Recent gains in both commodities have been driven by the ongoing West Asia war. Palm oil derivatives, a key input for soaps and personal care products, along with crude-linked packaging and freight costs, are key expenses for Indian consumer companies, which were only beginning to see a recovery in demand following tax relief measures introduced late last year.

Brent crude futures rose to $109.13 on Monday while Malaysian palm oil futures were at $1,195.53 (4,812.01 ringgit). The maker of Cinthol soaps and Goodknight mosquito repellent said it expects to offset the impact of cost increases through price hikes and other savings measures. REUTERS

Jindal Steel deploys syngas in furnaces

Jindal Steel on Monday said it has deployed syngas in galvanizing and colour coating line furnaces to counter the shortage of natural gas, LPG and propane, enabling the company to sustain operations amid supply disruptions. Syngas, or synthesis gas, is a clean-burning fuel that offers a way to convert waste and biomass into valuable energy, acting as a circular energy source.

The innovative switch to syngas—produced through gasification of coal—has allowed the company to mitigate fuel constraints in these critical finishing processes, where high-temperature furnaces are essential for applying zinc and colour coatings to steel strips used in construction, appliances and automotive sectors. "This integrated deployment of syngas across the steelmaking value chain sets a new benchmark for efficiency, sustainability, and energy self-reliance," Jindal Steel said. PTI

Tonse takes over as Yes Bank MD & CEO

Private sector lender Yes Bank on Monday said Vinay Muralidhar Tonse has taken charge as the managing director and chief executive officer (MD & CEO) of the bank for three years. Tonse, a former MD of State Bank of India, replaced Prashant Kumar who completed his extended term on 5 April.

Tonse is a seasoned banker with more than three and a half decades of experience spanning across treasury, retail banking, corporate banking, international operations and asset management. He is a commerce graduate from St. Joseph's College of Commerce, Bengaluru, and holds a master's degree in commerce from Bangalore University. During his stint as MD of SBI, he had the responsibility of the entire domestic network of the country's biggest lender consisting of nearly 23,000 branches with an employee strength of around 233,426 and business levels of ₹76 trillion as on 30 November 2025. PTI

Govt eyes induction stove loan subsidy with ADB, WB support

FROM PAGE 1

began, as consumers rushed to compensate for a shortage in LPG (liquefied petroleum gas) cylinders. On 12 March, an Amazon India spokesperson told *Mint* that sales of induction cooktops had increased 30X in two days. Prices of these cooktops, too, have risen. Basic models priced at around ₹1,800 saw an increase of about ₹100, while higher-end models witnessed steeper hikes, according to e-commerce data.

As demand rises, procurement of cooktops by EESL under the scheme is also being scaled up. The second person said that a tender for 100,000 cookstoves has closed recently. "Two more tenders are scheduled for a total of 500,000 units," this person said. "Given the growing interest, tenders may become more frequent and with more units on offer."

The NECP was launched with a target of deploying 2 million cookstoves. "By FY27, it was initially targeted that 1 million induction-based cookstoves would be deployed," the second person said, adding that the target was later cut by half due to weak demand.

"But now, given the rejuvenation of demand, the phase-wise target may have to be revised," the second person added.

An EESL spokesperson said

Nearly 65% of India's annual LPG demand is imported. PTI

the agency had an order book for 69,872 units as of 25 March, of which 16,526 units were successfully deployed, while the rest are under deployment.

"The tender of 200,000 units in phase one is under process," the spokesperson said. "Regarding subsidies, at present there is no such agreement with any financial institutions. EESL has been working with OEMs and the ministry (of power) to address the problems/ issues of industry."

A spokesperson for the World Bank said it is not directly involved in or financing EESL's NECP scheme, including any arrangements related to interest subvention or subsidies. Queries emailed to the spokespersons of the Union ministry of power and ADB went unanswered.

Nearly 65% of India's annual LPG demand of 33 million tonnes is imported—about 90% from West Asia—exposing households to global disruptions and putting pressure on the country's import bill.

Kirit Parikh, former member (energy) of the erstwhile Planning Commission of India, said the shift towards induction-based cooking is needed urgently, since "most of our LPG is imported and the imports are very concentrated".

"Induction cookstoves can very well replace LPG; however, availability should be ascertained," added Saurabh Kumar, former vice-chairman and MD of EESL. "One of the ways to ensure efficient adoption of linking of the programme to the PM Surya Ghar Yojana, wherein about 3 million households have already adopted solar power and they are connected to the discoms through net metering. Discoms have their data, so they can be easily approached."

Kumar added that while the current spike in demand is driven by the crisis, awareness of the benefits will be key to making the shift permanent.

rituraj.baruah@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Capacity curbs, disruptions weigh on FY26 passenger traffic growth

FROM PAGE 1

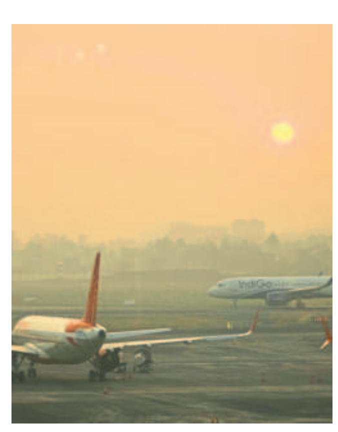
elevated at around 93%, Icra said. And all airlines have lined up aggressive expansion.

The fatal Air India crash in June 2025 triggered heightened regulatory scrutiny and stricter safety checks across the industry. This led to lower aircraft utilisation and operational delays. The operational meltdown in December at India's largest carrier, IndiGo, led the DGCA to cut 10% of its daily flights.

Another major drag has been aircraft availability. According to Icra, 13-15% of the industry's fleet remained grounded as of February 2026, primarily due to engine failures and supply chain constraints. This has directly reduced the number of planes in operation, limiting capacity addition even as demand remained robust.

International passenger traffic, a major growth driver over the past two years, has taken a hit. Growth has been affected by the closure of Pakistani airspace and restrictions in West Asia airspace due to the US-Iran war, forcing airlines to reroute long-haul flights. The war has also driven up fuel costs, resulting in higher fares and additional surcharges.

Indian airlines carried 30.3 million international passengers in the first 10 months of FY26, a year-on-year increase of 8.5%, compared to a stronger 14.1% growth in FY25.



Domestic passenger traffic has risen from 53.5 million in FY21 to 165.4 million in FY25. REUTERS

Domestic passenger traffic has risen from 53.5 million in FY21 to 165.4 million in FY25. Even with 3% growth in FY26, total passenger traffic would increase to around 170.3 million.

"While the start of the year was relatively strong, multiple disruptions—including the Pahalgam incident in April, India–Pakistan tensions in May, the Air India crash in June, the IndiGo crisis in December, and the West Asia conflict in March—have weighed on sector growth in FY26," said Jainam Shah, aviation analyst at Equirus Securities.

During the same period, Indian Railways, the preferred mode of transport for most Indians, reported a 3.54% increase in passengers to 7,410 million in FY26.

Despite the slowdown, India's top airlines are planning major expansion. Currently, IndiGo has 440 planes, the Air India Group has 291, Akasa Air has 37, and SpiceJet has about 35, taking the total fleet to 803 aircraft.

Over the next nine years, these airlines expect to add more than 1,000 planes. By 2035, IndiGo plans to add 900 aircraft, Air India 541, and Akasa Air 189.

Equirus's Shah said passenger demand is likely to remain strong enough to fill these new planes. However, it is uncertain whether all the aircraft on order will actually be delivered by 2035, and this will need close monitoring.

Icra expects the aviation industry to report losses of ₹17,000-18,000 crore in FY26, with only some improvement in FY27. It has also changed its outlook for the sector to negative from stable due to ongoing uncertainties.

However, some analysts still believe the outlook for FY27 is stable. "Looking ahead, the FY27 outlook appears stable, subject to geopolitical developments," Shah said. "In a normal scenario, industry growth is likely to remain in the high single digits, driven more by aircraft supply than demand, as underlying demand continues to be robust, reflected in healthy passenger load factors. Accordingly, airlines should prioritize faster aircraft inductions to bridge the supply gap."

IPO boom

Mainboard IPO fundraising surged sharply post-2020, hitting record highs in 2025.

Calendar year (opening date)	No. of issues	Issue amount (₹ crore)
2020	14	24,370
2021	63	1,18,723
2022	40	59,302
2023	56	48,946
2024	91	1,59,784
2025	102	1,71,903
2026*	11	14,014

Losing steam

Not only have average listing gains tapered off, but even premium listings are slipping, while discounted ones are steadily inching up.

Calendar year (opening date)	Average gain/loss in IPOs (%)	% of issues listed at premium	% of issues listed at discount
2020	46.0	71.4	28.6
2021	32.2	71.4	28.6
2022	10.7	65.0	35.0
2023	29.0	82.1	17.9
2024	30.3	78.0	22.0
2025	9.5	66.7	33.3
2026*	1.4	36.4	63.7

Returns slump

Average one-year returns for NSE mainboard IPOs was just 3.03% in 2025, the second lowest since 2021.

Calendar year (opening date)	Average (%) return after			
	1 month	3 months	6 months	1 year
2020	-2.23	9.58	37.15	106.54
2021	1.02	3.10	6.78	3.67
2022	-2.36	5.17	16.06	37.28
2023	6.77	16.29	25.64	41.84
2024	0.99	-2.19	0.73	-0.55
2025	-0.78	-3.02	-4.84	3.03
2026*	4.20	-	-	-

Slim pickings

The number of mainboard IPOs trading above their issue price a year after listing plunged to just 4 in 2025, the lowest since 2020 and down sharply from its 2024 peak.

Price after 1 year is more than offer price

Calendar year (opening date)	No. of issues	% of issues
2020	14	100
2021	36	57.1
2022	31	77.5
2023	44	78.6
2024	52	57.1
2025	4	3.9

Source: Prime database; *Listed till 15 March 2026; all data is for NSE listed companies on mainboard

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

WHY IPOs NO LONGER FEEL LIKE EASY WINS

The era of easy gains from initial public offerings appears to be nearing its end

Dipti Sharma
dipti.sharma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

A file photo of a worker wiping the statue of a bull at the National Stock Exchange, Mumbai. The bullish undertone of India's equity markets has currently shifted to caution.

BLOOMBERG

Hunny Yadav, a 30-year-old communications consultant, says his initial public offering (IPO) journey began with a feeling. The kind you get when everyone around you seems to be making easy money.

In 2022, IPOs felt magical: "60-65 out of 100 listed at a premium," Yadav recalls. And so, he invested in LIC, and DCX Systems and eMudhra. Early gains of 30-40% made it seem like he'd cracked the code. And he kept at it, investing in NTPC Green late in 2024.

By September 2025, however, some of the stocks that once soared and added value to his portfolio began slipping. At first, he wasn't worried. "Thoda correction hai (the correction is small); it'll bounce back," Yadav told himself. He held on, waiting for recovery. It never really came. Today, about 7% of his portfolio still sits in the red, a quiet reminder of that phase.

"Ek bhi IPO nahi laga (not a single IPO got allotted to me)," Yadav says about early 2024, even as other retail investors rushed in, mostly following influencers, not research. He stayed in the game through 2025, but with doubt creeping in. "Yeh investment band kar dena chahiye (I should stop this investment)," he admits.

Yadav's father, who quietly invested in mutual funds and SIPs, had steady gains—no frenzy, no swings, just consistency. The contrast was hard to ignore.

What puzzled Yadav most was the advice: buy more when markets fall. Logical in theory, impossible in practice. "How can one do that... when you're already fully invested and sitting on losses?," he says. "IPOs no longer feel like easy wins."

Yadav isn't rushing into IPOs anymore, and he is not alone. The frenzy seems to have faded.

For many retail investors, the IPO narrative has subtly changed. "The market just doesn't feel the same right now," says Pankaj Sabnani, a 39-year-old independent investor and research analyst, who once rode the wave of blockbuster listings but has stayed away from new issues over the past three to four months.

It wasn't always like this, says Sabnani. Back in September 2024, for instance, Bajaj Housing Finance delivered eye-popping gains; he recalls pocketing as much as 114%, the kind of return that fuelled the retail frenzy.

But the recent experience has been far more muted. Take Lenskart's listing in November last year—it debuted with a 3% loss and ended the day flat, turning what was a high-expectation bet into a "no gain, no loss" outcome, he says.

"Earlier, listings felt like quick wins. Now, even good names aren't giving that pop," says Sabnani, summing up a broader shift, where the easy money seems to have dried up, and retail enthusiasm is giving way to caution.

WAR IMPACT

The war in West Asia hasn't just bruised sentiment in the secondary market, it is now beginning to weigh on the primary market as well. A telling signal is fintech major PhonePe's decision to defer its much-anticipated IPO, highlighting how swiftly geopolitical tremors can seep into capital markets.

What's more, the move underscores how quickly market exuberance can give way to caution, with even high-profile listings pausing as the broader risk environment becomes less supportive.

PhonePe has explicitly cited geopolitical tensions, market volatility and the need for greater liquidity as key reasons to wait, reflecting a deferral rather than an abandonment of listing plans, says Pratik Loonker, managing director and head—equity capital markets, Axis Capital. "Its decision is indicative of a broader recalibration rather than a standalone event."

Even XED Executive Development, which aimed to become the first GIFT City IPO, withdrew its IPO after a tepid investor response amid the global uncertainty.

"The company decided to withdraw the public issue in the current environment and hopes to tap the market at an appropriate time in the future," it stated in a release.

XED chose not to go ahead despite meeting minimum subscription levels, citing volatile markets, tight liquidity and the risk of post-listing pressure given the relatively limited float. It called the move a proactive decision aimed at protecting investor interests and ensuring better pricing and long-term value when it returns.

Issuers are becoming more sensitive to market conditions, valuation expectations, and post-listing performance, says Loonker. After a phase where timing was driven by buoyant liquidity, companies that have the flexibility are now more willing to wait for better price discovery and stronger market stability before listing, he adds.

> Even if IPOs slowed and listing gains cooled off, the groundwork is still happening. Companies are out there meeting investors and doing roadshows; the intent is intact.

With geopolitical risks now spilling into primary markets, market participants see IPO activity slowing further and investors become even more selective.

Historically, the bar for IPOs goes higher during market drawdowns, reflecting in both the number of IPOs coming down as well as a derating in valuations, says Sushant Bhansali, chief executive officer, Ambit Asset Management. "We have observed this trend over the past few months as well and expect it to continue for the foreseeable future."

The flows are slowing down or stagnant for domestic institutions, and global institutions are still in selloff mode; this restricts supply for new paper subscriptions, Bhansali explains. Large IPOs will probably wait for markets to stabilize and flows to come back to get listed, especially companies primarily with an offer for sale (OFS) component as a larger part of their IPO plans, Bhansali adds.

AVOIDING COSTLY MISSTEPS

Retail investors need to be careful not to get caught on the wrong side of the cycle, say experts. When the tide is favourable, gains can come quickly and feel effortless, but markets have a way of turning when least expected, they point out. And when they do, the downside can be just as swift and unforgiving, with losses mounting far quicker than the gains that came before.

With listings turning increasingly lukewarm and post-listing returns losing sheen, IPOs may no longer be as rewarding, and could leave investors exposed.

Having said that, it raises a bigger question: is the IPO boom starting to lose steam, and is it time for retail investors to rethink the "quick buck" strategy?

Here's what *Mint's* analysis showed: the era of "easy gains" in IPOs, fuelled by the post-2020 liquidity wave, is beginning to fade. The overall success rate has slipped, with average one-year returns for NSE mainboard IPOs at just 3.03% in 2025, compared to a peak of 106.54% in 2020.

SME IPOs tell a similar story, with one-year returns at around 19%, also among the weakest in recent years. The market, it seems, is shifting from a liquidity-driven rally to a more selective, risk-aware phase.

The trend is even more stark beneath the surface. The number of mainboard IPOs trading above their issue price a year after listing plunged to just four in 2025—the lowest since 2020—down sharply from a peak of 52 in 2024. SME IPOs mirror this cooling, with only two such winners in 2025, compared to 42 in 2023 and 19 in 2024.

At the same time, the count of IPOs trading below their offer price after a year has been steadily rising since 2022.

Put together, the message is hard to miss: fewer IPOs are able to hold on to their listing gains, and more are slipping below issue prices. Investor enthusiasm is cooling and the pricing is getting less forgiving.

mint KEY NUMBERS

₹1.75 TRILLION
The amount 144 companies are proposing to raise after receiving approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India.

₹1.37 TRILLION
The amount 63 companies are looking to raise; they are awaiting approval from Sebi, according to a Prime Database report.

38
The number of companies including SBI Funds Management and Manipal Health Enterprises that filed IPO papers last month.

EASY MONEY PHASE OVER?

The data clearly signals a shift from a liquidity-driven IPO cycle to a more fundamentals-led market in the near to mid term, says Axis Capital's Loonker. It suggests that broad-based listing gains have faded, and investors will now differentiate more aggressively based on business quality, earnings visibility and valuation discipline, until the balance between greed and fear tilts again, he explains.

Loonker is of the opinion that the easy listing gains, as seen during the peak liquidity phase of 2023-25, are unlikely to return in the same broad-based manner. This, according to him, reflects a mix of cyclical and structural shifts; on the one hand is tighter liquidity and weaker secondary market support, and on the other, a more discerning investor base demanding clearer profitability visibility and more reasonable valuations.

"Listing gains will persist, but they are likely to be narrower, more selective, and driven by fundamentals rather than excess liquidity," Loonker says.

Pranav Haldea, managing director of Prime Database Group, says that for IPOs to happen, markets need a sense of stability or better yet, a bullish undertone. In volatile or bearish conditions, IPO activity tends to dry up quickly.

Right now, "the IPO market has clearly shifted from exuberance to caution." Ongoing geopolitical tensions have dented investor risk appetite and could weigh on corporate financials as well, says Haldea.

Liked this story? Share it by scanning the QR code.

WAIT-AND-WATCH MODE

Some market experts say it is less about rushing to list right now and more about getting clarity—once markets settle and the numbers are clearer, activity will pick up, they say.

Neha Agarwal, managing director & head of equity capital markets at JM Financial Institutional Securities, says companies are still working through the impact of the ongoing geopolitical tensions. "That's why many are choosing to wait; it gives time for markets to stabilize and for the financial impact to become clearer," she explains.

Agarwal adds that this phase is also sharpening investor behaviour. Filters are only getting stronger now, especially for businesses where the impact could linger on the P&L for longer. She sees this phase as a good clean-up for the market.

Even if IPOs have slowed and listing gains have cooled off, the groundwork is still happening. "Companies are out there meeting investors and doing roadshows; the intent is intact, just that valuation conversations are on hold for now," Agarwal adds. In her opinion, the biggest challenge for companies in this kind of market is timing the window more than anything else.

At the same time, Agarwal sees the shift in sentiment as a healthy one. "The euphoric IPO phase is behind us, but that's not necessarily negative—capital is now getting more selective, moving toward sectors with stronger fundamentals and clearly favouring larger, more established large- and mid-cap companies."

The pipeline of issues continues to be staggering, with 144 companies proposing to raise around ₹1.75 trillion waiting to hit the market after receiving approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), India's market regulator. Another 63 companies looking to raise around ₹1.37 trillion are awaiting approval, according to a Prime Database report of 31 March.

Amid the recent volatility, issuers are largely in wait-and-watch mode.

Given that an IPO is a once-in-a-lifetime event, market participants believe many would rather let approvals lapse than risk launching into a volatile or bearish market.

As many as 38 companies, including SBI Funds Management and Manipal Health Enterprises, filed preliminary IPO papers with Sebi last month, pointing to improving issuer sentiment, even as regulatory timelines played a role in the spike, as per reports. This is a sharp jump from 22 filings in March 2025 and 16 in March 2024, Sebi data showed, signalling a much stronger pipeline of upcoming public issues, reports stated.

Decoding your money personality —and its impact on market returns

Greater self-awareness about money behaviour can help most investors make more rational financial decisions

Shefali Anand
feedback@livemint.com

There's a saying that a volatile stock market doesn't make you lose money, your behaviour does. So, if you get nervous when markets fall—as they are doing now—and pull money out, you lock in a loss that may be avoidable in the long run.

Increasingly, financial advisers say understanding an investor's money personality is just as important as assessing risk appetite. Because traditional risk questionnaires often fail when markets actually tumble.

Advisers say investors typically believe they have a high risk appetite when stocks are rising. But when they see their principal shrinking, their reactions tell a different story.

The psychology test

How you behave in a market downturn—or otherwise in relation to money and financial decisions—has a lot to do with your psychology towards money.

"Post this kind of analysis, forget us being able to understand our clients, the clients start understanding themselves better. That helps them a lot," said Renu Maheshwari, a Sebi registered investment adviser and founder of Finscholarz Wealth Managers.

"These are the times which will test" their tolerance, said Rohini Pamarthi, assistant vice president at financial advisory firm International Money Matters.

Pamarthi said they ask clients questions about their relationship with money while growing up, the money mistakes they've seen others make, and similar life experiences to decode their money psychology.

For instance, people whose childhood was spent in an austere home where parents struggled to make ends meet might grow up to be extremely careful with money because they don't want to face scarcity again, said Pamarthi. "When they think of money, they get scared," she said. This in turn impacts how they spend, save and invest their money.

Understanding clients' emotional map helps advisers manage their reactions when markets move against them. "You know how they will react, how you have to calm them down," she said.

Combining this knowledge with traditional risk profiling can meaningfully impact investor behaviour.

"We are most often able to achieve long-term success with our clients because we are able to nudge their behaviour a little more objectively," said Maheshwari.

It helps clients too. "The more you are self-aware about your behaviour, your thought process, the more you'll be able to think rationally," said Brijesh Parikh, an RIA and founder of Planetwealth Financial Advisors.

Types of money personalities

Money psychology is still a nascent and evolving field, especially in India, and there is no standard methodology or universally accepted nomenclature around it. Individuals can also exhibit traits of multiple personality types at the same time.

Money personality types

Your attitude towards money influences your financial decision-making. Here are some common personality types and how to know if you fit the bill.

The avoider
- If someone asks about your bank balance, you don't even have a rough idea.
- You can't bring yourself to ask a friend to pay back their share of a group dinner.
- If you suddenly receive a large sum of money, you feel overwhelmed and put off making decisions about it.

The spender
- If you like an expensive pair of shoes in a store, you buy them outright without comparing prices.
- You frequently buy things you don't really need or use.
- You don't have a budget, or spend time to stick to one.

The financially anxious
- You overanalyse every financial decision.
- You check your bank balance or investments regularly, sometimes obsessively.
- You worry about money even if you have strong savings, steady income, and are meeting your financial goals.

The status-seeker
- You want to buy the latest trending handbag, even if you already have several.
- Money makes you feel accepted or validated.
- You may take a loan to pay for a luxury vacation.

The gambler
- You constantly seek new investments and ways to make quick money.
- You may take a loan to invest in an opportunity you believe will generate big returns.
- You rely more on instinct than analysis when making money decisions.

The saver
- If you like an expensive pair of shoes in a store, you immediately check if it's available cheaper online or wait for a sale.
- You pay bills on time to avoid late fees.
- If you get a salary increment or bonus, it goes straight into savings.

The balanced investor
- You have a growth-oriented investment plan and stick to it.
- You don't leave idle cash in low-interest savings accounts and move it to higher-return investments.
- You are willing to take measured risks to grow your portfolio.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Here are some broad financial personality categories and what they could mean for your money and financial decisions.

1. The avoiding type

Such people don't like to think or talk about money matters, either because they find the subject overwhelming, or because they think money is basically evil. They often leave it to someone else to manage their finances. This could be problematic if they don't have a proper grip on their financial situation. Studies have shown money avoiders often make poor financial decisions and tend to have lower net worth.

It's advisable to set aside some time to check your monthly spending or account statement to know where your money goes and what your financial liabilities are, so that you are not caught off guard financially.

2. The spending type

These individuals spend impulsively without evaluating affordability or necessity.

> Understanding clients' emotional map helps advisers manage their reactions when markets move against them

When the covid-19 pandemic struck in 2020, many people began spending aggressively, embracing YOLO—You Only Live Once, said Parikh. While that's great in the short term, if there are no checks to this, it can lead to financial problems and potentially debt.

Pamarthi shared the story of a client who has spent the generous income she made over the years and now has no savings despite being just a year away from retirement. "She's worried," said Pamarthi.

It's advisable to look at your income and spending to understand what you can afford. If you can't control the spending urge, set aside an amount, say in a different bank account, which can be spent loosely without impacting your overall financial goals.

3. The status seeker

For such individuals, money typically equals status. Spending decisions are often influenced by comparison—bigger homes, luxury cars, or expensive vacations. Like spenders, status seekers risk stretching finances beyond sustainable limits and accumulating costly debt. What helps: Anchor spending to clearly defined financial goals and long-term planning rather than social signalling.

4. The saving type

Such people fear unnecessary spending, look for bargains in shopping, and generally avoid debt like the plague. Often, money represents security for them. While saving is generally a good thing, being too saving-focused can have negative implications.

"Somewhere you may not be enjoying your life, if you count everything," said Pamarthi. Such people could also be too conservative in their investments which could make it hard to achieve their long-term financial goals.

It's advisable to make an investment plan based on your income and needs, and loosen up a little on spending.

5. The financially anxious type

It's one thing to save money, but another to fret about it constantly. Some people who are doing financially well, with no debt, remain worried that the money will run out or may not be enough in the future. Too much of this worrying can cause stress, and create conflict with family members who may wish to spend some money to enjoy life. It's advisable to seek objective financial assessment and maintain a clear emergency fund to ease worst-case fears.

6. The gambling type

They are prepared to take big risks to get big rewards and often enjoy the thrill of winning. They think: "I don't want to do any calculations, let's gamble, if it comes in favour then it will be beneficial otherwise, we'll lose money," said Parikh. This approach could have serious implications for finances if things go wrong with the big bets.

It's advisable to set aside a small portion of savings for making these all-out high-risk bets, while keeping the bulk of your money invested in places that suit your long-term financial goals.

7. The balanced investing type

These individuals seek growth but through a structured and disciplined investment plan.

"He knows that saving money alone isn't enough, and that he has to stay ahead of inflation or beyond," said Parikh. Such a person will typically have an investment plan with a healthy amount of risk for long-term growth.

It's advisable not to be overconfident and to stay focused on long-term financial goals rather than short-term growth opportunities, while also keeping a close check on spending and budgeting.

Advisers say there are no 'good' or 'bad' money personalities. Understanding which personality type you're more closely aligned with can help give you more control over your finances. Also, attitudes towards money can change with time, stage of life and personal experience, which in turn may have implications for your investments. "It needs to be continuously looked into," said Parikh.

Liked this story? Please share it by scanning the QR code.

POWER POINT

VISHAL DHAWAN

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

THREE BEARS THAT KNOCKED GOLD OFF ITS HIGH PEDESTAL

The global landscape has shifted significantly over the past few weeks, triggered by the unfolding geopolitical complexities in West Asia. As we stepped into 2026, the sentiment was one of cautious optimism. The probability of a global recession appeared slim, and investors were pivoting towards growth assets. Global equities were in favour, but the real "crowded trade" was the rising enthusiasm for gold and silver.

The consensus that was

At the start of the year, financial narrative felt almost settled.

The Fed factor: The debate wasn't if the US Fed would cut rates, but rather the timing and magnitude of those cuts.

Benign inflation: Both globally and closer to home in India, inflation appeared manageable, leading to a consensus that interest rates would either plateau or head downwards.

Safe-haven play: Gold was touted as a hedge against the twin threats of tariff wars and traditional geopolitical conflicts.

When the narrative hits reality

Conventional wisdom suggests that during times of high uncertainty, gold acts as a resilient anchor. Indeed, the initial run-up in gold prior to the war was largely attributed to this "flight to safety". However, the first month of the West Asia war has delivered a sharp lesson in market unpredictability.

Despite the heightened tension, these asset classes have behaved contrary to many investors' expectations. Gold, which many expected to be the "hero" of a crisis-ridden portfolio, has instead struggled to find its footing—effectively moving from a market "hit" to a "flop" in the short term.

Which were the "three bears" that made gold flop?

1. Inflationary fears (papa bear)

Papa bear, in my view, has been the resurgence of inflation anxiety globally. Following the severe inflationary pressures seen post-covid, we witnessed a period of relative cooling in prices. However, the recent sharp upturn in Brent crude oil prices caused global concern, triggering a complete "about-turn" in interest rate expectations. The markets now believe the likely direction for rates is upwards and typically, when interest rates rise, gold prices tend to soften somewhat.

> The traditional safe-haven asset has struggled to hold on despite rising tensions in West Asia

2. De-dollarization theory put to test (mama bear)

Mama bear has been the challenge to the de-dollarization theory. The prevailing belief was that, unlike in the past when the US dollar was the primary safe haven, this time would be different. Many expected investors to shun the greenback in favour of gold.

Instead, we have seen a dash for cash and a flight back to the dollar, leaving those who over-allocated to gold in anticipation of a weakening dollar disappointed.

3. Opportunity cost and liquidity (baby bear)

Finally, baby bear relates to the immediate need for liquidity in markets. In times of extreme geopolitical stress or uncertainty, speculators often sell their "winners" or most liquid assets—like gold—to cover losses in other parts of their portfolio or simply hold cash, waiting for conditions to improve.

The overexposure to gold in the run-up to the war meant that many of these speculators abandoned their gold positions and took their profits home.

What should you do now as an investor?

For the disciplined investor, this serves as a reminder that gold is not a one-way bet. While it has a place in a diversified portfolio for its low correlation with equities, using it as a tactical tool to time geopolitical events often results in frustration.

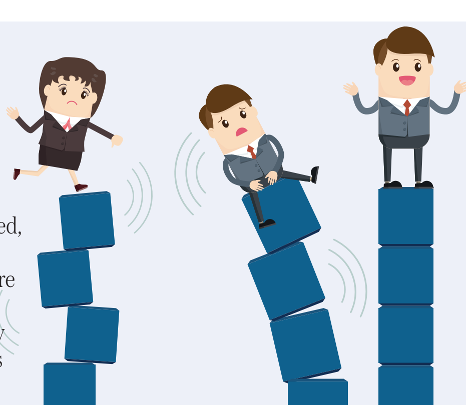
It always serves as a stark reminder that asset correlation and safe-haven status are never static. While the instinct to chase "crisis hedges" is strong, market prices often bake in expectations long before the event peaks. For long-term investors, this highlights the danger of over-tilting a portfolio based on narratives.

However, it is equally important that investors do not abandon gold simply because of its short-term movements over the past few weeks. Gold continues to hold its position as an asset that, over long periods of time, has a negative correlation with equities and therefore protects the portfolio from a sharp downturn.

Having a 10% to 15% allocation to gold continues to be a good idea for investors as a part of their overall allocations. In case you are overexposed, you need to reduce exposure and in case not, you need to right-weight your allocations to gold gradually.

Vishal Dhawan is founder and CEO of Plan Ahead Wealth Advisors, a Sebi-registered investment advisory firm

Check how your NPS investments are faring



There are very few retirement products that help you accumulate a retirement nest egg and one such product is the National Pension System (NPS). It is a market-linked, defined-contribution product that needs you to invest regularly in the funds of your choice. The returns are based on the performance of the fund that you choose. There are eleven pension fund managers to choose from and one of the ways to do that is by tracking the returns. Here is a breakdown of the performance of different funds—equity fund, government bond fund and corporate bond fund—of the private sector NPS. This NPS table show returns for pension fund managers who have completed at least 1 year

Returns (in %): 1 year, 3 years, 5 years

Fund Manager	Tier-1 account								
	Equity fund			Government bond fund			Corporate debt fund		
	1 year	3 years	5 years	1 year	3 years	5 years	1 year	3 years	5 years
Aditya Birla Sun Life	-0.26	12.19	11.09	-0.44	6.52	5.85	4.71	7.70	6.62
Axis Pension Fund	-2.81	11.30	-	-1.32	6.00	-	4.88	7.66	-
DSP Pension Fund	-6.80	-	-	-2.62	-	-	5.33	-	-
HDFC Pension Fund	1.39	12.71	11.77	-2.34	5.89	5.29	5.21	8.00	6.85
ICICI Pru. Pension Fund	0.37	13.69	12.32	-1.20	6.30	5.56	5.22	7.90	6.65
Kotak Mahindra Pension	0.35	13.34	12.38	-2.44	5.74	5.30	5.30	7.80	6.59
LIC Pension Fund	-0.08	11.86	11.68	-1.14	6.36	5.65	4.80	7.45	6.39
SBI Pension Funds	0.67	10.87	10.4	-1.11	6.48	5.60	5.20	7.83	6.63
Tata Pension Fund	2.29	14.28	-	-1.99	5.96	-	4.83	7.74	-
UTI Pension Fund	-1.36	13.22	12.01	-1.08	6.47	5.58	5.48	7.87	6.54
Benchmark index	NPS Equity Index			NPS Govt. Security Index			NPS Corporate Bond Index		
	-0.83	13.21	11.46	-0.61	6.64	5.64	4.6	7.26	6.44

Returns as on 2 April 2026; 1-year returns are absolute returns

Source: Npstrust.org.in

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

mint

Tax on workshop income earned in India

Harshal Bhuta

I have been residing in the United Arab Emirates, or UAE, for the past 13 years and am currently working as a practising dentist. I have been invited to conduct a two-day workshop for a dental association in India and will be receiving professional fees for the event. Will the income earned from this workshop be taxable in India?

—Name withheld on request

ASK MINT
NRI TAXATION

Given your 13-year stay in the UAE, it is reasonable to assume that you qualify as a non-resident under the provisions of the Income Tax Act, 2025 (applicable for 2026-27). For non-residents, income is taxable in India only if it is received or deemed to be received in India, or if it accrues or arises, or is deemed to accrue or arise, in India during the relevant financial year.

Income from professional services is generally regarded as accruing at the place where the services are actually performed. Since the proposed two-day dental workshop will be conducted in India, the income would be considered to accrue in India and, therefore, be taxable under domestic tax law on an accrual basis in India. This is in line with established judicial principles on source-based taxation of professional income.

That said, you may avail of the provisions of the India–UAE Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement (DTAA), if they are more beneficial than domestic tax law provisions.

Under the DTAA, income from professional services is covered by Article 14 (Independent Personal Services). Such income is taxable in India only if you have a fixed base available to you in India for rendering the services there, or if your stay in India exceeds 183 days in the relevant financial year. A fixed base refers to a specific and identifiable place, such as an office, clinic or workspace, that is regularly available for carrying out professional activities in India.

If you don't have a fixed base in India and your stay remains below 183 days during 2026-27, the income earned from the workshop would not be taxable in India under the DTAA provisions. To claim DTAA benefits, you will need to obtain a Tax Residency Certificate (TRC) from the UAE tax authorities and furnish Form 10F in India as required under tax rules. It is also advisable to maintain proper documentation supporting your period of stay in India and the exact nature of services rendered during the workshop.

Harshal Bhuta, partner, P. R. Bhuta & Co. CAs

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

OUR VIEW

ISTOCKPHOTO

Private credit: What if the US crisis hits India?

A private equity crisis is brewing in the West. While there may be no big cause for alarm in India, RBI should stay alert to contagion pathways and consider risk mitigation measures

There is usually a lull before a storm. Financial markets often mimic such natural phenomena, displaying blink-and-miss signs of disturbance before a full-blown crisis. In many advanced economies, nascent signals of trouble have arisen that could—if left unaddressed—hit global finance and send several players to the sick bay. In the eye of the swirl lies the US market for private credit—in which private equity (PE) firms deploy private investor funds, leveraged with loans from various sources, to lend outside the formal banking system to sundry borrowers. Investors have been queuing up with redemption requests at the doors of PE funds—especially those feared to have overlent to AI-rattled software businesses. To honour these, firms need to run down their loan books, which may not always be possible; some players have resorted to extra borrowings to give investors their money back. While this has compounded the crisis, many firms—such as Ares, Apollo and Blackrock—have been forced to limit redemptions.

This has all the typical signs of a gathering maelstrom, especially the investor rush to withdraw funds and affected firms taking on fresh debt to repay what they owe. Things may reach a breaking point for many reasons, but the main issue for us is whether a similar crisis might afflict Indian financial markets. In India, annual PE deals are estimated in a range of $30-40 billion, while assets under PE management are thought to be thrice as much or more. The local market is not huge, and may even seem tiny in contrast with America's, but global PE firms operate in India and we must stay alert for potential contagion effects that may disturb financial stability here. Unfortunately, this risk is not trivial. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has been issuing routine warnings about the adverse consequences of a possible blowout in the private-credit market, which forms an intricate web of links with other financial institutions. So the country's central bank, which tracks knock-on risks from one segment to another, may soon have to install guardrails in advance. Recall how RBI had acted pre-emptively to cushion the impact of America's 2007-08 subprime lending crisis. Today's troubles seem less serious, but private credit is also more opaque as a field.

Two issues hold importance here. The first is the unbridled tendency of fund managers to chase higher risk for higher returns, encouraged to a large degree by the waterfall incentive structure in PE firms, with big rewards for those on top. What gives them a licence is the lack of regulatory oversight, which emboldens managers to take on higher levels of risk. This leads to the second problem: funds exploiting cracks in regulation and weak coordination among regulators. Notably, while all other lenders—from commercial banks to non-bank finance companies—must toe RBI's line on prudential norms, PE players operate as 'alternate investment funds,' a category regulated by the Securities Exchange Board of India. Decades ago, PE firms acted as equity investors; today, as a large part of their business, they lend. Ideally, all credit extenders should be regulated by RBI to ensure they meet capital adequacy, asset classification and income recognition norms. Otherwise, the overall credit market looks skewed, with one set of players burdened with safety rules and another free to go 'all in' on high-stake plays. This is a surefire formula for tragedy should a storm reach our shores.

THEIR VIEW

RBI's external borrowings reset expands access to foreign capital

It represents greater market orientation and shows confidence in the economy's macro fundamentals

SAUMITRA BHADURI
is professor, Madras School of Economics

After years of marginal tweaks, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) undertook one of the most consequential reforms in its External Commercial Borrowing (ECB) framework in February this year. Over the decades, commercial loans raised by Indian resident entities have been regulated under tightly-controlled regimes, with caps on the quantum of annual borrowing, ceilings on interest spreads, prescriptive maturity conditions and rigid end-use norms. The new framework, which raises borrowing limits and removes the all-in cost ceiling, represents a structural shift towards a calibrated and market-driven approach.

ECBs are an important source of funding for Indian corporates. According to RBI data, outstanding ECBs stood at $190.4 billion as of September 2024, marginally higher than in June and March 2024.

Of this, about $155 billion comprised non-rupee and non-foreign direct investment-related components. The private sector accounted for roughly 63% of outstanding ECBs (amounting to about $97.6 billion), with public sector entities making up the remaining 37% (about $55.5 billion).

Insofar as new ECB registrations are concerned, these rose sharply to $49.2 billion in 2023-24 from $26.6 billion in 2022-23, even though these still stood slightly below the $52.9 billion recorded in 2019-20 during the era of ultra-low global interest rates. In 2024-25 (up to November 2024), ECB registrations had already reached $33.8 billion.

Despite the increase in absolute flows, ECB and foreign currency convertible bond registrations as a share of gross domestic product (GDP) have declined—from 1.9% in 2019-20 to about 1.2% in 2023-24. Similarly, outstanding ECBs as a percentage of GDP have moderated from 5.7% to 4.9% over the same period.

The divergence between India's rising nominal stock and falling relative burden indicates that our economy has outgrown its need for external commercial borrowings. Against this context, the central bank's decision to liberalize the ECB framework was imperative.

To understand the broader picture, our ECBs must be placed in the context of total external debt. As of the end of December 2024, according to RBI data, India's total external debt stood at $717.9 billion, while outstanding ECBs were about $190.4 billion, implying a share of around 26%.

The remainder includes sovereign borrowings, multilateral and bilateral loans, deposits from non-resident Indians, trade credit and other liabilities. Against this macroeconomic backdrop, RBI's ECB reform appears less like an aggressive gamble and more like a confident recalibration.

The revised framework raises the borrowing limit to $1 billion or 300% of a borrower's net worth, whichever of the two is higher. This links a company's ECB capacity to its balance-sheet strength, which is better than having a fixed ceiling for all borrowers. It marks a momentous departure from the earlier provision, under which firms could raise only up to $750 million annually under the automatic route, often constraining large capital-intensive projects and necessitating additional approvals for foreign debt.

Equally significant is the removal of the all-in-cost ceiling. Previously, ECB interest rates were capped relative to benchmark rates. But loan pricing can now align with market conditions, signalling greater regulatory maturity.

These reforms clearly enhance allocative efficiency. The easing of access to global capital markets that they enable can reduce financing costs, diversify funding sources and support long-gestation infrastructure projects.

However, it is important to recognize that this greater flexibility comes with higher underlying risks. Foreign currency borrowing inevitably exposes firms to exchange-rate volatility. A sharp depreciation of the rupee can materially increase debt-servicing obligations in domestic currency terms. Similarly, a sudden tightening of global liquidity conditions could raise refinancing costs and strain the balance sheets of borrowers.

India, however, enters this phase with two key strengths.

First, its external debt burden has remained moderate and stable. External debt has hovered within a narrow 17-19% of GDP range between 2019-20 and 2024-25, even as its stock rose from about $560-610 billion in 2020–21 to over $730 billion by 2024-25. Nominal GDP growth has kept the ratio contained, and it remains lower than in many comparable emerging markets.

Second, risk management has improved. RBI data shows that around two-thirds of outstanding ECBs were hedged as of September 2024, up from roughly 55% two years earlier. This has provided a stronger buffer against exchange-rate volatility.

India's ECB reform is, therefore, a recognition that a $4 trillion economy cannot operate indefinitely under rules crafted for a much smaller system. It reflects confidence in India's macro fundamentals, foreign exchange buffers and regulatory capacity.

10 YEARS AGO


www.livemint.com

mint

CORP: Bezos praises Amazon India's Tatkal scheme

POLITICS: Will BJP manage to pull off an upset in Assam assembly elections?

COMPANIES: Tata Steel to begin sale process of UK assets by Monday

GLOBAL: Pfizer, Allergan scrap $160 billion deal after US tax rule change

FFC RECOMMENDATIONS

Fiscal rules relaxed for some states

Cabinet allows some states to relax existing cap on fiscal deficit of 3% of GSDP by half a percentage point

INDIA'S DIABETES WAKE-UP CALL

Are Infosys founders not happy with Vishal Sikka?

QUICK EDIT

Threat to civilization

LIC may invest ₹2.7 trillion in capital markets this fiscal year

INSIDE

Another forgettable quarter for corporate earnings?

JUST A THOUGHT

What we have found over the years in the marketplace is that derivatives have been an extraordinarily useful vehicle to transfer risk from those who shouldn't be taking it to those who are willing to and are capable of doing so.

ALAN GREENSPAN

MY VIEW | MUSING MACRO

Onshore rupee market versus offshore: Resolve the gaps

AJIT RANADE

is senior fellow with Pune International Centre

The Indian rupee lost 10% against the US dollar in 2025-26, making it one of the worst performances in emerging markets. March alone saw a 4.24% drop, the steepest in any single month in six years, with the rupee briefly breaching the 95 level against the dollar. To defend the currency, the Reserve bank of India (RBI) sold dollars heavily from its reserves, which fell by $30.5 billion in March. Crude oil at $115 per barrel was adding further strain. RBI then mounted a bold two-step intervention. It first capped banks' net open rupee positions at $100 million. That led banks to simply transfer their exposure to corporates and hedge funds, which then used the arbitrage between onshore and offshore rates to press further against the rupee. RBI then banned banks entirely from offering rupee non-deliverable forward (NDF) contracts to any client and forbade the rebooking of cancelled ones. The rupee responded with its largest single-day gain in over 12 years. These gaps make RBI's stiff action look justified. But there are also questions that outlast any single crisis.

Can a price signal be gagged? An NDF is a derivative contract, settled in dollars, traded in financial centres such as London, Singapore, Hong Kong and Dubai. Because the rupee is not fully convertible, non-residents who wish to hedge or speculate on the rupee use NDFs instead of the onshore market. Daily NDF volumes globally are estimated to be $150 billion, making the market large, liquid and informative.

Market bids are a form of price discovery. When the NDF market signals sharp rupee weakness, it yields information about capital flow expectations, oil prices, global risk appetite and India's current account trajectory. That signal may be uncomfortable and exaggerated at times by herd behaviour or thin liquidity. But suppressing it does not make the underlying pressures disappear. It merely removes the thermometer while the fever persists. RBI's intervention was necessary to prevent a disorderly overshoot. But it is not a verdict that the NDF market has no legitimate role.

The RBI Task Force on Offshore Rupee Markets, chaired by Usha Thorat in 2019, confirmed that the influence between offshore and onshore rates is bidirectional in normal times. It turns unidirectional, with NDFs driving the onshore market, only during episodes of stress like the taper tantrum of 2013. But in general, these NDFs are not always the tail wagging the dog. Excessive speculation in thin, one-sided conditions can cause damage. But the right response is to deepen the onshore market and not permanently gag offshore signals.

The rupee's weakness was manifest in the exodus over two years of funds pulled out by foreign institutional investors. In 2025-26, the outflow on this account was a record ₹1.6 trillion-odd, reflecting a global risk-off sentiment, geopolitical anxiety amid the Iran war and concerns over India's current account as well as investment policy. NDF signals should be seen in this light.

Act to deepen local trading in currency derivatives and aim for an economy that backs the rupee

The Thorat panel had recommended attracting NDF volumes onshore through the GIFT City's International Financial Services Centre (IFSC), simpler KYC norms, extended trading hours and permitting of hedging up to $100 million without requiring proof of exposure. Brazil and Indonesia have partially succeeded in similar efforts. Since both countries are commodity exporters with structural trade surpluses, they have organic dollar inflows, which makes it feasible to offer onshore liquidity and pricing.

India lacks this advantage. With a persistent current account deficit (CAD), the rupee faces structural depreciation. Non-residents also have little incentive to bring hedging onshore when India's tax treatment of derivatives is less favourable than offshore centres and compliance costs higher. In addition, the regulatory environment can change overnight, as the latest move shows. The liquidity chicken-and-egg problem is real: without non-resident participation, onshore markets cannot deepen; without deep onshore markets, non-residents will not come.

India runs a persistent current account deficit and has higher inflation than its major trading partners. So, some rupee depreciation is not only inevitable but desirable. It maintains export competitiveness and acts as a system-wide shock absorber when external conditions deteriorate.

As for the next steps, *first*, the NDF ban should be temporary. RBI should get back to the Thorat taskforce recommendations. Deepen IFSC trading, ease non-resident access, harmonize tax treatment and extend onshore trading hours.

Second, accelerate the rupee's internationalization. Only about 5% of India's trade is settled in rupees. The more trade is invoiced and settled in rupees, the less the NDF market would matter. Every step that reduces structural dollar dependence would reduce the speculative demand that feeds it.

Third, we need strong foreign direct investment (FDI). Net FDI has turned negative, which is unacceptable. It is the only durable counterweight to CAD-driven rupee weakness. Tax and regulatory policy must tilt in favour of patient capital.

Fourth, currency stability rests on macroeconomic fundamentals—the fiscal balance, inflation and growth. Policy predictability is itself a form of currency defence.

The NDF market is a symptom, not the disease. The cure lies in a deeper onshore market, an internationalizing rupee and an economy that earns the world's confidence rather than having to buy it with reserves.

MY VIEW | ECONOMIC GRAVITY

India should use the oil shock to build a more resilient economy

It's an opportunity to build reserves, deepen hedges and accelerate our energy transition as we pursue the Viksit Bharat goal

PRACHI MISHRA
is professor of economics at Ashoka University and director and head of Ashoka Isaac Centre for Public Policy.

REUTERS

The world has been through this before. Oil prices spike, supply chains shudder and emerging economies absorb the pain while advanced nations reach for their strategic reserves. But the conflict now roiling West Asia carries a twist that policymakers must not overlook: this is not a health shock, as covid was. It is an energy shock rooted in geopolitics. This distinction matters.

When covid struck, the blow fell directly on final consumption and production. Today's shock is upstream, striking at the intermediate inputs that power virtually everything else. That changes the transmission mechanism, policy toolkit and likely duration of pain. Comparisons with the 1973 Opec embargo or 1979 Iranian Revolution are more useful; the latter saw India turn to the International Monetary Fund in 1981 for its then-largest loan of 5 million special drawing rights. The magnitude is serious: crude prices for the Indian basket surged to $112 a barrel in March this year from $69 just a month earlier. Even after a favourable change in the mix, household liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) costs jumped from ₹853 per 14.2kg cylinder to ₹913 in a fortnight, and quantity restrictions threaten to compound the damage. Oil and gas account for nearly a third of India's import bill. A rise in crude prices widens the current account deficit, stokes inflation and places an additional fiscal burden.

Our projections suggest that if the Indian basket stabilizes near $125 per barrel by end-June, macroeconomic damage will be manageable. The Centre's fiscal deficit would rise to 4.5% of GDP (from 4.3%), and the current account deficit to 1.2% of GDP (from 0.8%). Two often-overlooked cushions matter here: *ad valorem* customs duties boost revenues and India's position as the world's fifth largest refined petroleum exporter means higher crude prices are partially offset through export revenues. But if the war persists and the basket reaches $150 per barrel by December, the effects would turn non-linear—with the fiscal deficit approaching 5%, current account deficit near 4% and CPI inflation breaching the 4% target even with limited consumer pass-through. The government has already reached for excise duty cuts, but that instrument is blunt and finite. The exchequer cannot absorb an open-ended subsidy; a ₹100 increase in the price of a subsidized LPG cylinder after June would reduce the potential subsidy burden by ₹6,000 crore through December, a measure worth considering.

How long will the shock last? Honest forecasters admit they do not know. A three-month baseline is plausible if diplomacy stabilizes shipping lanes and the Strait of Hormuz stays open. But history counsels humility: even after conflicts end, energy market normalization takes months, not days. Tanker routing, insurance premiums and refinery schedules all have their own momentum.

India faces this shock in a relatively enviable position, what the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) governor termed a Goldilocks moment of reasonable growth, declining inflation and a resilient external sector. That buffer is real but not unlimited. The global economy proved surprisingly resilient through 2025, but 2026 looks fragile. Uncertainty acts as a tax on investment, as firms delay decisions and households cut discretionary spending. The indirect effects through confidence and markets may be worse than the direct hit to the fuel bill.

The immediate policy agenda has three aims. *First*, monetary policy must balance the inflationary impulse from energy costs against the growth slowdown the same shock induces, a genuine dilemma. *Second*, RBI has already moved to contain rupee volatility; further intervention may be warranted if capital flows turn choppier. *Third*, ensure structural resilience.

India's strategic petroleum reserves cover only 74 days of demand, compared with 96 for Thailand and 173 for Japan. Hedging mechanisms for public sector oil importers are underdeveloped. The push for ethanol blending is directionally right but must be weighed against overall costs as well as fuel efficiency. Building genuine shock absorbers, not just emergency responses, must become a standing priority.

All this lands with uncomfortable force on India's most ambitious aspiration: Viksit Bharat by 2047—the goal of becoming a high-income economy by the centenary of independence. The arithmetic is unsparing. India's per capita income stands at roughly $2,800 today. Reaching the high-income threshold of around $14,000 requires nominal per capita dollar income to grow at 8% or more every year for two decades, implying real GDP growth of at least 8% annually, without interruption. The arithmetic becomes even more demanding if the rupee continues to weaken against the dollar.

Shocks like the current one make that target harder to achieve. Consider the compounding arithmetic: a single year of 6% growth instead of 8.5% does not merely delay Viksit Bharat by one year, it creates a gap that requires above-trend growth in every subsequent year to close.

In fact, we have not fully recovered the output lost to the pandemic. In a world of higher-frequency disruptions, including pandemics, geopolitical crises, climate shocks and trade wars, the sustainable growth rate required between disruptive episodes must be higher still. Viksit Bharat demands not just ambition, but an economic growth model that is more resilient, diversified and capable of bouncing back faster.

India faces a stress test. It is not the first, and in a turbulent world, it will not be the last. The appropriate response is neither panic nor complacency, but a clear-eyed diagnosis and structural reform: build reserves, deepen hedges, accelerate the energy transition and set growth targets that account for the world as it is, not as we wish it to be. Viksit Bharat is achievable. For that, each shock must be treated as an opportunity to further build an economy resilient enough to absorb the next one before it arrives. The government's swift measures to support exporters signals exactly this kind of agility. As they say, never waste a crisis.

MINT CURATOR

Will the Gulf war spell a global food crisis? Not anytime soon

Some fertilizers have gotten scarce but there's no food scarcity today

JAVIER BLAS
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering energy and commodities.

Some argue that surging fertilizer prices could impact future crops. MINT

An old commodity-trade adage is that the Middle East "sells hydrocarbons to buy carbohydrates." The desert states send out their oil and natural gas, and in comes wheat and rice. There are a few things produced in the Gulf, however, that are crucial to global food production: nitrogen fertilizer such as urea and ammonia, and the gas used to make them.

So the war in Iran—and its blockage of the Strait of Hormuz waterway—has prompted warnings about another bout of global food inflation similar to the one that followed Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Despite such fears, the agricultural market isn't at risk today, at least in the short term. The price of oil might have been soaring but the world's plentiful food stocks are acting as a balm on commodity prices.

Of course, the usual caveats apply to the US and Israeli war on Iran: a prolonged or broader conflict would upend all kinds of market assumptions. For now, though, the situation isn't like 2022, when Vladimir Putin's forces attacked Europe's bread-basket, turning farmland into a battlefield. At the time, Russia and Ukraine together accounted for a quarter of the world's wheat and barley exports, roughly 15% of our corn, and nearly half of all sunflower seeds.

Instead of fertile land, this Gulf war is being fought over deserts and a strip of sea. For central bankers worrying about rising fuel costs, it's a welcome difference. The stability in farming offers an important reprieve on inflation. Four years ago, supermarket buys pushed up prices for households. So far this time, our grocery bills are steadier. Since the war started, wheat and corn prices have risen a mere 4%. Soyabeans are up about 1%, while rice is down nearly 6%. In the first two months of the Russia-Ukraine war, by contrast, European wheat prices rose more than 70% to an all-time high of €450. Today, they're around €200.

The importance of rice is often overlooked in the West, but it's the staple diet for half the world's population, including a billion or so undernourished Asians and West Africans. The worst riots during the 2007-08 food crisis were about the cost of rice. Right now, benchmark prices for the cereal in the wholesale Asian market are approaching a 19-year low of $350 a tonne.

It's not just wholesale commodities offering relief. Electricity prices remain well anchored today, shielding bakeries, food processors and supermarkets from 2022-style cost spikes. Nor is packaging getting more expensive; four years ago, cardboard and steel costs hit record highs.

Still, the food Cassandras aren't entirely wrong. They argue that the problem is the impact of surging fertilizer prices on future crops. The Gulf's nitrogen-fertilizer products cannot reach the global market via Hormuz. At the same time, natural gas shortages are forcing Asian fertilizer plants to curb output. US benchmark urea prices have risen to nearly $690 a tonne, up about 60% from pre-war levels. In 2022, urea peaked at close to $900 as the world briefly lost Russian supply and many European plants had to close as gas prices soared.

Pessimists warn that without fertilizers, farming production will plunge, causing food shortages by the next harvest. Cereal yields typically drop by about 40% after a year without any nitrogen fertilizer. But farmers are unlikely to cut its use to zero immediately; the reduction would be phased. Any impact on crops would be smaller initially. Moreover, nitrogen fertilizer isn't the only nutrient used in farming. Phosphate and potash are equally prevalent. The price of potassium chloride, a potash-based fertilizer, jumped more than 400% to $1,200 after the Ukraine war started, as Russia and Belarus had their exports curbed. Today, it trades at $370, little changed since the US and Israelis started bombing Iran. Worries about fertilizer also overlook how the farm economy of most developing countries works. In Asia in particular, fertilizers are heavily subsidized, so high prices don't presage a food crisis, rather a fiscal shock as governments bear the brunt of the cost increase.

Thankfully, we are better prepared today to handle war shockwaves. Developing countries have strengthened their farming industries, establishing safety nets to help offset production expenses. Multilateral development banks can and should do more. Wheat and rice global stocks are also plentiful after several good years of harvest.

During the 2007-08 food crisis, global wheat inventories stood at a 26-year low of about 129 million tonnes. Now they're near a high at 280 million tonnes. The same is true for rice, where stocks were just 75 million tonnes in 2007-08 and are 190 million tonnes today. Much of that is concentrated in India and China, but it creates a buffer.

If the US doesn't find an off-ramp from the war, energy and fertilizer costs may rise to a point where the farm sector cracks. We're not there yet.

MY VIEW | A VISIBLE HAND

What unites and differentiates three poll-bound states

NARAYAN RAMACHANDRAN

is chairman, InKlude Labs. Read Narayan's Mint columns at www.livemint.com/avisiblehand

Kerala, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal are going to the polls this month. These three states are dissimilar in many ways. But they are similar in that they have had unique sociopolitical paths from the time of India's independence. These paths are quite distinct from those followed by the other states of India.

After independence, the State Reorganization Commission enacted in 1956 set up these new states. Since then, in Tamil Nadu, the Congress Party ruled for the initial 10 years. For the remaining 59 years, non-Congress parties like the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and All-India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) have ruled. In West Bengal, the Congress ruled for the initial 20 years and non-Congress governments have been in power for the last 49 years. In Kerala, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) has ruled for 20 years while the CPI (Marxist)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) has been in power for 49 years. In Kerala alone, there has been a balanced alternation between the UDF and LDF in recent years. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which rules at the Centre, has never been in power in these three states. While there are other states where major national parties have not held power, there is none where this has added up to more than half the years since 1947.

The sociopolitical history of Tamil Nadu and its predecessor Madras State is fascinating. The Dravidian political movement has its roots in the Justice Party formed in 1916. It championed non-Brahmin rights, social justice and affirmative action, laying the groundwork for Dravidian politics. This movement gained momentum when the Justice Party merged with the Dravidar Kazhagam (DK), a social reform organization founded in 1944 by E.V. Ramasamy, popularly known as Periyar. The DMK was established in 1949 as a breakaway faction of the DK led by C.N. Annadurai, widely known as Anna. A further split occurred in the DMK, then led by M.K. Karunanidhi, when the popular matinee idol M.G. Ramachandran (MGR) established the AIADMK in 1972.

In contrast, in Kerala, the first democratically elected Communist government in the world came to power helmed by E.M.S. Namboodripad in 1957. Here the egalitarian and anti-caste movements of Sree Narayana Guru and Ayyankali merged with the Marxist thinking of early socialists in the Congress party. The character of social integration was different in Kerala because Dalit integration was tied to class-based struggles and land reforms. In Tamil Nadu, Dalits have largely remained outside the DMK/AIADMK mainstream because that transformation has focused on 'intermediate castes.'

Kerala, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal took socioeconomic paths that set them apart from other states

In many ways, Bengal was the intellectual epicentre of ferment in colonial India. Political strains of communism co-existed with nationalism in this cauldron. The Communist Party of India (CPI) gained a foothold through peasant and labour movements in jute mills and dockyards. The Tebagha movement led by the Communist Party agitated for a third (*tebhaga*) of the harvest being given to landlords instead of half, and just a decade later, an extremist left-wing movement was born in Naxalbari. West Bengal's transformation was based on land reform and class struggle, rather than on universalizing education. Like the CPI(M), Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress (TMC) is also a welfarist party. Unlike it, the TMC is more of a personality-driven than a cadre-based party.

For these elections, the manifestoes of the regional parties in these three states reflect this path dependence. The DMK is industry-friendly, welfarist and populist in its promises. The CPI(M) in Kerala is oriented towards social justice, but its populism is more structural than in Tamil Nadu (not just election oriented). For instance, the DMK manifesto promises ₹8,000 for the purchase of household appliances and a basic income of ₹2,000 for all poor women.

The CPI(M) promises an increase in social security pensions for the elderly, jobs for women and continuing expansion of healthcare as well as education. Mamata Banerjee's TMC phrases its populism as "10 *protigya*" or 10 pledges, which include a basic income for poor women, jobs for youth and increased old-age pensions. In that sense, the TMC's current approach is a bit of a blend of the welfarism of Tamil Nadu and Kerala.

All three states face a serious fiscal situation. Kerala and West Bengal have high debt-to-gross state domestic product (GSDP) ratios of about 40%. Distressingly, neither seems able to reorient policy towards industry so that growth in income can exceed the growth of state expenditure and debt. Tamil Nadu's expansion rate of welfarism has outstripped its revenue growth, but it has stayed industry-friendly and can hold its own against Maharashtra, Gujarat and Karnataka in attracting investment. Tamil Nadu's annual GSDP growth is structurally about 2-3 percentage points higher than that of West Bengal or Kerala.

The three poll-bound states' challenges are quite different. Tamil Nadu must reduce crony-capitalism and corruption. It must also extend its social schemes to include Dalits. Kerala and West Bengal need to shed their hostility to industry and find ways to grow faster. West Bengal still has some way to go on reducing multidimensional poverty and improving literacy and education.

P.S: "To discard what is unwanted, and to retain what is needed, is what reform means," said Periyar E.V. Ramasamy.

How to keep a retreat routine at home

ISTOCKPHOTO

To replicate a healthy schedule of morning light, clean meals and consistent sleep, design a routine that easily fits your regular life

Anushka Patodia
feedback@livemint.com

At a retreat, *dincharya* feels almost natural. You wake up early because the light comes in gently and there's nowhere urgent to be. Meals arrive at predictable times and there is space in between activities for you to gather your thoughts. Then you return to the city, where mornings begin with alarms and emails, dinner often ends up being at 10.30pm, and "routine" feels like something that belongs to someone else's life.

Dincharya, Ayurveda's concept of daily rhythm, often gets mistaken for a rigid spiritual timetable: wake before sunrise, drink warm water, oil your body, meditate, and sleep early. In reality, it's far less performative. *Dincharya* is simply the idea that the body works best when it moves in rhythm with light and dark, hunger and rest, activity and recovery. As Gita Ramesh of the Kairali Ayurvedic Group explains: "*Dincharya* is not rigid. It is structural, not mechanical." Dr Isaac Mathai, founder of Soukya International, a medical institute and retreat in Bengaluru, adds, "When rhythm is lost, the nervous system remains overstimulated, and everything else becomes harder to maintain."

SLEEP EARLY TO WAKE UP EARLY

Dincharya has acquired a reputation for severity, as though it demands a pre-dawn alarm and monk-like discipline. In reality, what guests struggle with most after returning home is not oil pulling or meditation, it's sleep. The biggest challenge is early waking, says Ramesh adding, "At home, silence and structure are replaced by noise, traffic, work and social demands. Quiet time has to be consciously created." But the problem isn't that people can't wake at sunrise, it's that they can't sleep at midnight. And without sleep rhythm, everything else becomes cosmetic. "If your body is rested and your mind is calm, you are not compromising your routine," she says.

Mathai agrees that rigid adherence without context can backfire. "*Dincharya* is compromised less by waking late and more by sleeping late, eating irregularly and living in constant sympathetic overdrive." Dr Shaji Pampalayam, chief wellness officer at Dharana at Shillim, Maharashtra offers a practical solution: "If waking before sunrise isn't possible, maintaining a fixed wake-up time becomes the next best anchor. Here, consistency matters more than perfection."

FOLLOW A STRUCTURED ROUTINE

Retreats come with well-being routines, including therapies, consultations and curated diets. But when guests return home, most of that disappears. It's like when you come back from a vacation and immediately shift back into urgency. Yet even small adjustments can have a disproportionate impact.

"An early, light, screen-free dinner, morning breathing or yoga, and a consistent sleep schedule can noticeably improve digestion, hormonal balance and emotional stability," says Pampalayam. Interestingly, the body doesn't take long to respond. "If you follow a structured routine, you can see changes in sleep, digestion, mood and energy in as little as 3 to 5 days," says Ramesh. Mathai observes that the first shift is often subtler than energy. "When wake times, meals and stimulation become predictable, irritability reduces and mental chatter softens."

Pampalayam agrees that once routine stabilizes, repair can begin surprisingly early. "With specific integrated approaches, biological self-repair can initiate from around 72 hours onwards." Which explains why retreat experiences often feel transformative—and why the challenge lies in sustaining their logic at home. Retreats work because they remove factors such as decision fatigue, digital noise, social pressure, and the constant feeling of being behind.

It's easy to assume that therapies create change, but practitioners insist otherwise. "Therapies accelerate healing, but predictability of routine shifts the body into repair mode," says Pampalayam. If there's one behaviour these experts would eliminate from city life, it's late dinners. "Late-night eating impairs digestion, disturbs sleep cycles and increases inflammation," says Pampalayam. "Even shifting dinner one to two hours earlier can change overall well-being." Mathai adds that the issue rarely exists in isolation. "Late-night screen exposure combined with delayed sleep stacks stimulation at the very time the body is preparing for repair."

DESIGN A REALISTIC RHYTHM

Most people return from a retreat with the same plan: Follow everything, including the early waking, the clean meals, and the idea of "no screens after 8". Then Monday arrives, and the plan collapses under a calendar invite. That's why insiders rarely advise replication; instead, they advise translation.

"*Dincharya* is really about creating a harmonious rhythm that suits your life, not about just sticking to a single time," says Ramesh. "If someone can't make it before sunrise it's okay, as long as they are still aligning with calm, mindful practices, regular sleep and balanced meals." Dr Mathai puts it more bluntly: "We advise guests to translate principles rather than replicate environments. Urban life does not require a Himalayan schedule," he says. "It requires rhythm within reality; consistent wake times, mindful meals, morning light and reduced late stimulation."

Dincharya isn't a checklist to complete. It's a steady set of cues you give the body, daily, so it can stop guessing. In that sense, it is less about willpower and more about environment design. As Ramesh says, it begins with the basics. "Having my balanced meal and getting my hours of sleep are non-negotiables." Pampalayam's non-negotiables are more physical, but the idea is the same: "Daily yoga and breathwork to centre my nervous system, a balanced mix of strength and cardio training, maintaining a disciplined sleep cycle, and ending the day with gratitude." Mathai's is almost deceptively simple. "Morning exposure to natural light, combined with a few minutes of deep breathing and gentle stretches," he says. "Even brief morning light signals the brain to regulate hormonal cycles. Breathwork anchors the nervous system. It is simple, efficient, and profoundly stabilising." The retreat version of *dincharya* can feel like a lifestyle. The city version needs to feel like a system.

Plan your day

Every body is different, and every household has its own constraints. But if you're looking for a rhythm that's structured enough to settle your system and flexible enough to survive a workday, here is a *dincharya*-style routine Dr Issac Mathai of Soukya, Bengaluru recommends:

6–6.30am: Wake naturally. Expose yourself to natural light within 10–20 minutes.

6.30–7am: Perform gentle mobility exercises, *surya namaskar*, and *pranayama*.

7.30–8.30am: Eat a light, warm, easily digestible breakfast.

9am onwards: Schedule your most challenging work for the first half of the day.

12.30–1.30pm: Eat your main meal of the day. Chew calmly, avoid screens.

4.30–5pm: Do some gentle stretches and get a hydration break.

6.30–7:30pm: Eat a light, easily digestible dinner and go out for a stroll.

9–10pm: Engage in relaxing activities such as reading. Prepare to sleep.

ISTOCKPHOTO

All you need to know about 'fibremaxxing'

The latest dietary obsession spotlights a nutrient that's good for metabolism

Shrenik Avlani
feedback@livemint.com

Protein is passé. In 2026, the nutritional trend the world is obsessed with is "fibremaxxing". The term is self-explanatory: you max out on fibre by including fibre-rich foods or supplements in your diet. As with most trends these days, it is fuelled by social media and Gen Z, which is why you are seeing more people posting pictures of bean bowls, chia puddings, lentil salads and whole-grain meals. "Fibremaxxing's popularity is driven by social media wellness trends, a growing awareness of gut health and research linking fibre intake with reduced risk of chronic diseases," notes Ruchika Jain, head dietician, Fortis Hospital, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi.

Acknowledging that fibremaxxing is a trend, Cult Fit nutrition expert Chaitanya Vijay Yerawadekar contends that this particular one is powered by a true public health problem. "A majority of adults consume less fibre than recommended owing to modern diets that are heavily biased towards refined grains and ultra-processed foods. So, fibremaxxing becomes less about a fad and more about filling a longstanding nutritional void," says Yerawadekar. For decades, fibre was mostly noted for helping prevent constipation. Remember Isabgol? Latest research, however, shows that its advantages go far beyond digestive health. Dietary fibre is needed to ensure upkeep of our metabolism and gut.

> The generally recommended intake of fibre for an adult is 25-30 grams per day

Besides aiding the gut by inducing bowel movements, fibre also acts as a prebiotic to feed the good gut bacteria and assists in regulating our blood sugar levels by slowing the rate of glucose absorption. It also assists our bodies in maintaining balanced fats in our bloodstream through the binding of bile acids. "A 2019 study published in the *Lancet* journal found that those who consumed 25–29 grams dietary fibre per day, reported a substantially lower incidence of heart disease, stroke, type 2 diabetes, and colorectal cancer compared to those who did not," says Yerawadekar.

Although fibre has its advantages, increasing its consumption can cause many problems. "Excessive fibre intake, especially when increased rapidly, can cause bloating, gas, abdominal discomfort, constipation or diarrhoea, and reduced absorption of minerals like iron or zinc. Very high fibre without enough fluids may worsen digestive issues. Gradual increases with adequate hydration are important," warns Jain.

The best way to increase your fibre intake is to do it gradually. Yerawadekar suggests adding fibre by approximately 5 grams a week for the digestive system to acclimatize. The recommended daily intake of fibre for an adult is 25–30 grams, and this should be derived from our diet, including vegetables, fruits, legumes, grains, nuts, and seeds, advises Bhakti Samant, chief dietician at the Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital, Mumbai. Simple modifications to your daily diet such as choosing whole grain breads instead of white bread, including a cup of lentils or beans or adding a vegetable in every meal will make sure you have enough fibre without having to turn to supplements.

Def Leppard's Rick Allen finds calm in the *shruti* box

The drummer of the iconic band talks about the tools he uses to manage anxiety and his philanthropic work

Mahalakshmi Prabhakaran
mahalakshmi.prabhakaran@livemint.com

A young boy singing along at their Mumbai concert is a memory that Rick Allen, 63, drummer for Def Leppard will carry with him from the legendary band's recent India tour. "This young boy, must have been about 11, was singing every single word to every single song. And then when Joe (Elliott, the lead vocalist) came back on and did *Two Steps*, he just started to weep. He looked like he just arrived in heaven. It is moments like this that really touch us," says Allen in an interview with *Mint* in Bengaluru.

As the drummer of the Rock and Roll Hall of Fame band, Allen is acutely aware of music's emotional pull. "Over the years, I've realized that music is a time machine. For the older generations that come to see us, I see them having really special moments when they hear certain songs. You see the emotional reactions, sometimes there are tears of joy," he says.

TUNING INWARD WITH SOUND

While playing sold-out shows continues to drive him, Allen—who survived a life-altering car accident in December 1984 but lost his left arm—finds solace in music when things get overwhelming. "I think music, when you add intention to it, can heal. And that is why I find myself constantly listening to tones," he says before sharing the tools he uses to get into the zone.

"I bought myself a little *shruti* box in 2006. I also bought a synthesizer later. What I do is I choose a musical note—like a C or an F—for the day and let it play for hours." That's not all. As Allen reveals, he's got an entire room in his house set up for a sound bath. "When I start to feel myself getting a little anxious or a little too much in my head, I'll go downstairs into the sound bath and immerse myself in the music. One of the things that really helps me is if I join in and start to make the tones myself say, by humming. Just making that sound and connecting with where I feel it in my body brings me back into the moment. It's so easy."

Rick Allen has been the drummer for Def Leppard since 1978

Dressed in a denim on denim look, Allen is a picture of calm as he opens up over the course of the interview. At one point, he confesses that he continues to suffer from PTSD but quickly adds that he now has tools to stop himself from spiraling. Breathing, he says, is a really good tool. "I am aware of the fact that my breathing gets shallow when I am feeling anxious. So, then, I force myself to go into deep breathing to feel normal again. The breath work I do at this time, however, is breathing out more than I breathe in. Doing that helps settle down my nervous system, which can easily get triggered."

Tapping into gratitude is another grounding technique. "Feeling gratitude for the things and people I have in life, as opposed to things that I don't have, helps me. It stops me from spiraling."

A DRUM CIRCLE THAT HEALS

At a Def Leppard concert, Allen's drumming is the beating heart of the show. That he delivers those thundering beats—earning him the moniker "Thunder God"—with one hand and his feet only adds to the sense of awe. But beyond the packed stadiums, there is quieter work he has been doing.

Along with his wife, Lauren Monroe, Allen runs the Raven Drum Foundation, which since 2001 has been offering "mind, body and drumming integrated workshops" to communities such as war veterans who are at risk of post-traumatic stress (PTS). Recalling how it began, Allen says: "My wife and I were in a special place in Denver called Red Rocks and a friend of ours brought some kids from Afghanistan. A few of them had lost limbs to landmines. We were all in a bus and we had a few hand drums with us. So, we set up a rhythm and had the kids play along. It was such a profound experience because the kids started to open up and talk to us. And then, my wife and I realised that if playing drums could work for young kids, why wouldn't this work for others?"

Soon, the couple found themselves holding drum circles in women's shelters and prisons. "We began working in prisons and that was so interesting because we would be doing the drumming sessions and these rival gangs would be doing dance-offs against each other!" Today, the foundation works a lot with soldiers, war veterans, firefighters and first responders. "It's a powerful shared experience where the participants are invited to let go of things they want to or set intentions for things they want to bring into their lives," he says. Allen's philanthropic work also extends to the mental wellness app Ahhaa, founded by Ashwin Srisailam and Diane Bacchus. As a brand ambassador, he supports its focus on helping users build mental fitness through daily practices such as meditation, journalling, and gratitude. In a world dominated by negative content, Allen believes such platforms are increasingly necessary. "We're not supposed to be driven by negativity or by trying to provoke reactions out of people. We're supposed to be collaborative, to be there for each other," he says.

For someone who refused to quit when it might have been the easier choice, Allen's journey is inspiring. "I didn't give up because the people in my life—my family, my band mates, the band's producer Mutt Lange—rallied around me." Ask him what lessons he hopes younger generations can take away from his life and his answer is a continuation of that thread: "As I get older, the more I realize the importance of surrounding yourself with people that lift you up. It's good to gravitate towards people who are easy to be around. I think that's the most important thing for me."